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Journalist, feminist icon Gloria Steinem dies at 92

Sunalini Mathew
NEW DELHI

Writer-activist-feminist Gloria Steinem died at her home in New York on Wednesday. She was 92. Through her life, her work, and her words, she spoke for the rights of women. An icon of the second-wave feminist movement in the U.S., she believed women had the right to make decisions on their bodies and reframed abortion as “re-productive freedom”.

She visited India several times since the age of 22, meeting women in villages and cities. In 1972, she co-founded the popular Ms. magazine. She died after writing her memoir, *An Unexpected Life*, due for release internationally later this month.



FULL REPORT
» PAGE 16

Bar Council has no power to punish law students: SC

Top court says only the universities they are enrolled in can take action; it rebukes BCI's attempt to intimidate NALSAR students who opposed inviting CJI Kant as chief guest at their convocation

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday declared that the Bar Council of India (BCI) and its Chairperson, Manan Kumar Mishra, lack jurisdiction to discipline or penalise law students, rebuking the regulatory body's attempts to intimidate NALSAR students exercising their constitutional right to protest.

The court insisted on clarifying the limits of the BCI's powers though the latter had revoked its August 13 letters to NALSAR administration to launch an inquiry against the students and to the State Bar Councils to block their professional enrolment.

The students had protested against having Chief



On an in-depth consideration of the issue, we are of the opinion that the Advocates Act, 1961 does not confer, expressly or impliedly, any power on the Bar Council of India and State Bar Councils to take any disciplinary or punitive action against law students

SUPREME COURT

Justice Kant as chief guest at their convocation following his oral comments in court comparing youth to “cockroaches” and “parasites”.

Right to dissent

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said the order, drawing the boundary for the BCI, was designed to

safeguard university space and students' right to freely express dissent against future attempts to breach.

“The BCI has no jurisdiction or statutory competence as regards students. That is for their universities,” Chief Justice Kant observed.

“On an in-depth consideration of the issue, we are of the opinion that the Ad-

vocates Act, 1961 does not confer, expressly or impliedly, any power on the Bar Council of India and State Bar Councils to take any disciplinary or punitive action against law students,” the court recorded in the order.

Mr. Mishra, who was present, said the BCI had a role in regulating legal education. But the court said the BCI could step in only after enrolment. Its disciplinary powers under the Advocates Act, 1961 were, obviously, limited to registered advocates.

“Till then, BCI did not come into the picture... To say a student will not be enrolled...” Justice Joymaya Bagchi said, leaving the sentence unfinished.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12

IN BRIEF



HC dismisses Stalin's plea on election result

CHENNAI
The Madras HC on Thursday dismissed a petition by DMK president M.K. Stalin to declare him elected from the Kolathur Assembly constituency after nullifying the victory of TVK's V.S. Babu. » Page 4

Delhi court grants bail to Satyendar Jain in STP case

NEW DELHI
A Delhi court on Thursday granted bail to AAP leader Satyendar Jain, who was arrested on August 18 in a case involving alleged irregularities in the tendering process for sewage treatment plants (STPs) in the city. » Page 2

Birthday bash



All smiles: A child dressed as Lord Krishna celebrating Janmashtami along with his schoolmates in Hyderabad on Thursday. AP

GDP revisions: Congress asks govt. to explain methodology

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Thursday posed four questions to the Central government over the latest GDP estimates and sought an explanation for a cumulative downward revision of ₹43 lakh crore in the estimated size of the Indian economy over the past four years. The party also questioned the methodology used to calculate real growth.

DETAILS ON
» PAGE 13

Air quality panel taps ISRO to improve tracking of Punjab, Haryana farm fires

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

As part of its preparation to buffer winter pollution in the Delhi National Capital Region (NCR), the Commission for Air Quality Management in NCR and Adjoining Areas (CAQM) has said it is in discussion with authorities in Punjab and Haryana to improve measurement of stubble fires.

“While fire counts reported from satellite passes may not be the most accurate picture of the extent of farm fires, we are in talks with the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) and Punjab to have better ‘ground truthing’ protocols,” Rajesh Varma, Chairman, CAQM, said at a press briefing on Thursday.

Farm fires in Punjab are a major contributor to pollution during some weeks of October and November



A farmer burning stubble on the outskirts of Chandigarh. FILE PHOTO

when monsoon withdrawal stalls westerly winds that flush out particulate matter pollution from vehicles, industry, agriculture waste, and firecrackers.

In this period, paddy stubble left over after harvesting is frequently burnt to make way for sowing wheat. Over a whole winter, farm fires contribute no more than 15% of the particulate matter pollu-

tion but on certain weeks, this share can spike to almost 44%, several studies have shown.

Mounting evidence

Mr. Varma's comments come in the context of mounting evidence since 2024 that the Punjab government's claims of having reduced farm fires by 90% since 2021 were exaggerated. This is because

these were counted through tracking fires via two satellites passing over India during the day and allegedly encouraging several farmers, who otherwise face the prospect of fines for being caught setting fire to their fields, to burn stubble in the evenings. An ISRO Space Applications Centre study found a gradual shift in peak fire activity from 1.30 p.m. in 2020 to around 5 p.m. in 2024 to avoid detection by polar-orbiting satellites.

“The resolution of satellite sensors matters and the pollution level depends on straw quantity, moisture, combustion efficiency and per-pollutant emission factors that satellites can't measure. But we have asked the ISRO to give us a basic protocol so we can make a start in getting a better estimate than fire counts,” Mr. Varma said.



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Anyone can stand surety for DUSU candidates: Delhi HC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Thursday clarified that candidates contesting the upcoming Delhi University Students’ Union (DUSU) elections do not need to obtain the consent of their parents or guardians to furnish the mandatory ₹1-lakh surety. Any individual financially capable of paying the amount could stand as surety, said the court while hearing a plea by All India Students’ Association (AISA) members. Ananya Raturi and Akshat Shikhar of AISA had on Wednesday moved the court against an order by the DUSU Election Committee directing candidates to file an affidavit containing consent of their parents or guardians, along with a ₹1-lakh surety from them.

“The condition is fair and reasonable except that the bond need not only be given by the parents and can be given by anyone, including a guardian who is in a position to pay ₹1 lakh and stand as a surety,” Justice Jasmeet Singh said, disposing of the plea.

The petitioners argued that the affidavit violates election-related rules. Candidates are also required to furnish their own bank details along with those of their parents or guardians as part of the undertaking.

The university, however, told the court that the requirement was not new and had also been part of the affidavit for the 2025 elections.

The DUSU polls are scheduled for September 18.

T.N. House resolves to recognise Tamil as main language of Madras HC

All parties unanimously support the resolution stating that Constitution provides a mechanism under which the Governor can authorise use of State’s official language in High Court proceedings

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Assembly on Thursday unanimously adopted a resolution moved by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, urging the Centre to recognise Tamil as the principal language of the Madras High Court and take action to facilitate its use.

Legal avenues
The resolution said the Constitution, while upholding the federal principle and recognising the multilingual and multi-cultural character of the country, provided various legal avenues for States to use their respective official languages.

It said Tamil had been declared the official language of the State under



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay in the Assembly on Thursday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Section 2 of the Tamil Nadu Official Language Act, 1956. Sections 4-A and 4-B of the Act provided legal recognition for recording evidence in Tamil and for issuing judgments, decrees, and orders in Tamil in civil and criminal courts, tribunals, rent courts, and revenue courts functioning under the High Court, it added.

Article 348(2) of the Constitution provided a mechanism under which

the Governor of a State, with prior consent of the President, could authorise the use of the official language of the State in the proceedings of the High Court, the resolution said.

The resolution recalled that the Assembly had unanimously passed a resolution on December 6, 2006, seeking the use of Tamil in the Madras High Court, and had forwarded it to the Union government.

The Chief Minister said

the resolution was not against any other language, but was intended to make Tamil the principal language of the Madras High Court.

DMK MLA S. Regupathy listed several measures taken by the DMK to make Tamil the principal language of the High Court. He said former Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi took steps to get Tamil recognised as a Classical Language.

The AIADMK’s C. Ve. Shanmugam urged the government to take steps to change the name of the Madras High Court to Tamil Nadu High Court. All political parties supported the resolution.

Later, Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar declared that the resolution had been adopted unanimously. (With inputs from PTI)

Raghav Chadha, AAP spar over his name being marked ‘shifted’ in Punjab draft roll

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



This is a clear case of political vendetta, said Raghav Chadha. FILE PHOTO

Rajya Sabha MP Raghav Chadha on Thursday attacked the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government in Punjab for allegedly marking his name as “shifted” in the draft electoral list published as part of the special intensive revision (SIR) process. Hitting back, AAP Delhi president Saurabh Bharadwaj alleged that Mr. Chadha might lose his Rajya Sabha seat because his “vote got deleted in SIR”.

Mr. Chadha, who was elected to the Rajya Sabha in 2022 on an AAP nomination, joined the BJP in April.

“The AAP government in Punjab has now taken its politics of revenge to the draft electoral roll. I am a sitting Rajya Sabha MP from Punjab, with my voter ID registered in Mohali. Yet my name has been classified as “shifted” in the draft roll,” Mr. Chadha said in a post on X on Thursday.

He said he is already in the process of availing the remedies provided under

special intensive revision (SIR) guidelines. “This does not seem like a mere clerical mistake. This is a clear case of political vendetta,” he said.

AAP said in a release that SIR is conducted by the Election Commission (EC), not the State government, so Punjab had no role in deciding whose name is included or deleted from the electoral roll.

“It is a matter of public record that Raghav Chadha has been living in Delhi and not in Punjab. If he no longer resides in Punjab, maintaining or shifting his voter registration was his own responsibility,” the party

said. AAP also claimed that it has received information from EC sources that Mr. Chadha was trying to get his voter registration made in Rajinder Nagar, Delhi, through a backdated process. “If any such backdated or unlawful exercise has taken place, it must be investigated and the entire truth brought before the public,” the statement added.

What the rule says
Under EC rules, a person can register to vote from a particular booth if he is an ordinary resident there, i.e. for a period of not less than six months. In the detailed guidelines issued by the EC for SIR, a specific provision - cited as Paragraph 4(d) - requires that names of “certain categories of people”, if they were already flagged/identified in the electoral database, must be automatically carried into the draft electoral roll rather than be dropped for want of a fresh enumeration form.

No coercive action against Gymkhana Club until next hearing, Centre assures Delhi HC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Centre on Thursday told the Delhi High Court that it would not take any coercive action against the Delhi Gymkhana Club until the next date of hearing on September 16.

The submission was made before Justice Avneesh Jhingan, who was hearing petitions by club

member Vijay Khurana and the Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd. Staff Welfare Association challenging a June 29 show-cause notice issued by the Land and Development Office (L&DO) ordering the club’s eviction from the 27.3-acre premises on Safdarjung Road.

Additional Solicitor General Chetan Sharma told the court that the Centre’s earlier undertaking not to

take coercive action would continue. “We will not take any coercive action till the next date (September 16),” Mr. Sharma said.

The petitions arise from the L&DO’s May 22 decision terminating the club’s perpetual lease and directing it to vacate the land on the ground of “strengthening and securing defence infrastructure”.

The Centre had earlier

argued that the High Court had no legal authority to prevent the government from taking possession of the land after termination of the perpetual lease and issuance of the eviction notice.

It also contended that the perpetual lease was a bilateral agreement between the government and the club.

Since an individual club

member was neither a party nor privy to the agreement, the member could not independently restrain the authorities from exercising their contractual rights, the Centre said.

Mr. Khurana has alleged in his lawsuit that the reasons cited by the Centre, including defence infrastructure and security, were “vague” and “generalised” and amounted to a “sham”.



L&DO had terminated the club’s perpetual lease and directed it to vacate the land. FILE PHOTO

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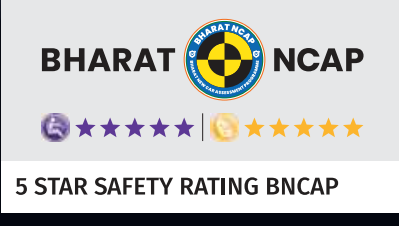




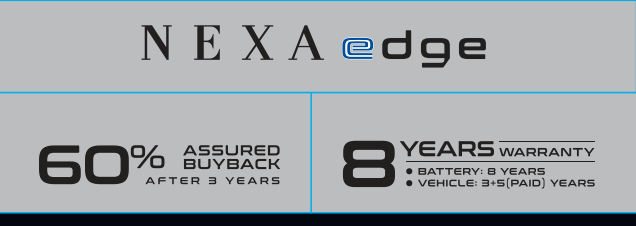
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INBRIEF



Ram Temple Trust’s new CEO holds meeting with members

Ram Temple Trust’s Chief Executive Officer, Air Marshal Jeetendra Mishra (retd), on Thursday attended his first meeting with members and office-bearers after reaching Ayodhya, where he was briefed on the trust’s functioning, including its accounting and administrative arrangements. The meeting was held at the trust’s Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra office at Ramghat. “It was an introductory meeting where I met other members of the trust. I will take a few more days to understand my role and duties,” Mr. Mishra told reporters. Though Mr. Mishra has been appointed as the CEO, he has not formally taken charge of the post yet, sources said. PTI

Brahmbhatt launches new CJP outfit, flays parent party

Activist Manish Brahmbhatt on Thursday announced the launch of the Cockroach Janta Party-Democratic (CJP-D), positioning it as an alternative platform to the Cockroach Janta Party, accusing the Abhijeet Dipke-led organisation of moving away from the student-led movement from which it had emerged. Mr. Brahmbhatt, who had earlier protested against the composition of the CJP’s national working committee, alleged that the organisation had become a “handpicked team” aligned with Aam Aadmi Party convener Arvind Kejriwal. PTI

Five killed as heavy rain batters U.P.; Ganga nears the danger mark in Bihar

In Himachal, torrential rain brings debris onto the Chandigarh-Shimla highway in Solan district, hampering traffic movement; train services hit in West Bengal after soil beneath tracks erodes

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Heavy rain disrupted normal life across several States on Thursday, claiming five lives in Uttar Pradesh, pushing the Ganga towards the danger mark in Bihar, triggering landslides and road blockades in Himachal Pradesh and disrupting train services in West Bengal.

In U.P., five persons, including three members of a family, were killed in separate rain-related incidents in Chitrakoot, Amethi and Barabanki districts. A mud house collapsed at Barachi village in Chitrakoot amid rain, killing a 32-year-old man and his two children, aged five and one.

A 66-year-old man died after a mud wall collapsed amid heavy rain at Naya Purwa village in Amethi on Wednesday evening. In Barabanki, among the 23 districts in the State affected by floods, a 62-year-old man died and his son-in-



Commuters using a boat to navigate a flooded road following an increase in the Ganga’s water level in Prayagraj on Thursday. PTI

law was injured after a mud wall collapsed on them in Dhanouli village late on Wednesday night.

CM surveys situation

In Bihar, the water level in the Ganga rose to a dangerous level on Thursday, threatening floods in several areas of Saran, Munger, Jehanabad, Bhagalpur, Begusarai, Lakhisarai, Bhojpur, Buxar and Patna districts. Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and former Chief Minister Nitish Kumar took stock of the

rising water level from different points in Patna and urged people to remain alert. “Inspected the rising water level of Mother Ganga. Considering the potential flood situation, necessary instructions were given to the officials concerned so that the general public faces no inconvenience and the safety of lives and property can be ensured,” Mr. Choudhary said in a post on X.

In Himachal Pradesh, heavy rain brought debris onto the Chandigarh-Shim-

la highway in Solan district, affecting traffic movement, while run-off water inundated shops in the Jabli area near Dharampur.

Landslides in the Naddi area of Kangra district damaged key gravity pipelines supplying drinking water to Dharamshala, disrupting water supply to several parts of the town. As many as 95 roads remained closed for traffic across the State. A wet spell is likely to continue till September 9.

In West Bengal, the Damodar Valley Corporation began issuing flood alerts for downstream areas after releasing water from its Maithon and Panchet reservoirs amid heavy rainfall and increased inflow.

Train services were also affected in the Howrah-Malda division of the Eastern railway in West Bengal after soil beneath the tracks between Tilpara and New Farakka eroded following heavy rain.

(With inputs from Amarnath Tewary in Patna)

‘Breach of alliance ethics’: Cong. ends ties with Rajior Dal

Press Trust of India
GUWAHATI

The Opposition Congress on Thursday announced the termination of all ties with Akhil Gogoi-led Rajior Dal in Assam, citing “breach of alliance ethics”.

The decision, taken on the direction of State Congress president Gaurav Gogoi, came into immediate effect, the party said in a statement.

A circular to this effect, signed by APCC General Secretary (Organisation) Ramanna Baruah, was issued on Wednesday, it said.

The Congress said it had forged an electoral alliance with pan-India Left parties and several regional outfits, including Rajior Dal, ahead of the previous Lok Sabha and Assembly elections, with the objective of presenting a united opposition against “communal forces”.

“However, for a majority of this period, the leadership of Rajior Dal continuously engaged in malicious propaganda and character assassination against the Congress party, violating the norms and decorum of the coalition,” it alleged.



Rajior Dal chief Akhil Gogoi

“On multiple occasions, the Rajior Dal leadership made baseless, unwarranted and derogatory remarks against leaders of other constituent parties within the Opposition alliance, repeatedly undermining the fundamental ethics of the alliance,” it alleged.

In light of such conduct, violating alliance ethics, the Congress said it is no longer viable to sustain political ties with Rajior Dal.

No reaction

No immediate reaction was available from the Rajior Dal leadership.

The Congress and Rajior Dal were part of a six-party opposition alliance during the last Assembly election and won 19 and two seats, respectively, in the 126-member House.

Akash Anand in need of more political maturity, won’t give him key party roles: BSP chief

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) chief Mayawati on Thursday said her nephew and party national coordinator Akash Anand needs to become more politically mature and decided against giving him with any major responsibility in the party.

“I have allowed Akash Anand to work in the party, which is before all of you, but he still needs to become more mature. Till then, it would not be appropriate to give him a major responsibility in the party,” the BSP chief said while addressing a national-level meeting of party office-bearers in Lucknow.

The former Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister also announced that her party will contest all elections across the country, however big or small, on its own.



BSP chief Mayawati with her nephew Akash Anand. FILE PHOTO

Ms. Mayawati termed the Congress “strongly anti-Dalit and anti-Ambedkar” and alleged that Opposition parties are engaged in “misleading and misguiding” Dalits and other sections of the Bahujan society. She accused them of “favouring some Dalit groups and misleading people by making baseless claims and spreading false propaganda”.

She also dubbed demonstrations and road

blockades as political and electoral gimmicks. “The BSP is the only Ambedkarite party in the country that is free from such political and electoral gimmicks. It is dedicated to the welfare and well-being of the entire society, especially the poor, labourers, exploited, oppressed, and neglected. The living proof of this is the development done by the BSP-led government in Uttar Pradesh for four terms,” she said.

Madras High Court dismisses Stalin’s plea to declare him elected from T.N.’s Kolathur

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Thursday dismissed as not maintainable a writ petition filed by DMK president M.K. Stalin to order the 100% counting of VVPAT slips of the Kolathur Assembly constituency, and consequently declare him elected after nullifying the victory of TVK MLA V.S. Babu.

The First Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan, however, granted liberty to the former Chief Minister to pursue other remedies, such as filing an election petition with a request to the election tribunal to condone the delay in filing the plea.

The Bench agreed with senior counsel G. Rajagopalan and Dama Seshadri Naidu, appearing for the Election Commission of India (EC), that a writ petition



Former CM M.K. Stalin

could not be entertained by circumventing a constitutional bar on entertaining a challenge to parliamentary/Assembly constituency election except by way of an election petition.

‘A Pandora’s box’

The judges concurred with the EC’s argument that entertaining such a writ petition might open a Pandora’s box.

Authoring the verdict, the Chief Justice said Mr. Stalin had insisted on 100% counting of VVPAT slips on

the basis of alleged anomalies discovered by his representative, senior counsel N.R. Elango, during the checking and verification of the burnt memory/microcontroller in 5% (14 out of 286 machines) of the EVMs used in Kolathur constituency by a team of engineers from the EVM manufacturers.

An inquiry into such alleged anomalies could not be undertaken on the basis of affidavits filed before a writ court since it requires a full-fledged trial, including expert evidence on the technical functioning of the EVM and VVPAT units, which could be done only before an election tribunal, the Bench added.

During the course of arguments, senior counsel Kapil Sibal, representing Mr. Stalin, told the court that the writ petitioner had applied for 5% EVM verification on May 7 (within three days of declaration of results on May 4), but the

EC had commenced the process only on July 29, and ended it on August 5, by which time the 45-day limitation period for filing an election petition had expired.

To this, the Bench said: “This Court is not persuaded that this circumstance can enlarge the jurisdiction of this Court under Article 226 (writ jurisdiction) of the Constitution in the face of the express constitutional bar under Article 329(b). Suffice it to observe that a difficulty of this kind, even where genuine, is not a ground on which the constitutional bar can be circumvented. It is, at best, a ground to be urged before the forum vested with jurisdiction to try the dispute.”

The judges said the 5% EVM verification mechanism had been engrafted by the Supreme Court as an additional safeguard, and not in substitution of the remedy of an election petition.

Jarange-Patil agrees to take IV fluids on Day 6 of fast

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI

Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil on Thursday agreed to take IV fluids without breaking his fast as it entered its sixth day. “I will continue to fast until the issues are resolved. I am giving two days to the government to act,” he said.

Meanwhile, his supporters across the Marathwada region continued to stage “rasta roko” protests, blocking major national highways in a bid to put pressure on the government to implement their demands.

A bandh was announced in Jalna on Thursday to extend support to the protest. Similar bandhs have been observed in Beed and Dharashiv. Supporters blocked bus movement at Dharashiv Kendriya Bus Junction and a bike rally was taken out in Beed city.

‘What happened was wrong. Gen Z has united against what is going wrong’

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

From prominent student leaders in the Jharkhand protests to students at IIT Delhi and NALSAR, Hyderabad, student representatives highlighted their respective issues at ‘GenZ on the rise’, a convention organised by All India Students’ Association (AISA) at Delhi’s Constitution Club of India.

AISA’s national president Neha, who went on hunger strike for 23 days and became a prominent face during the Jantar Mantar protest, moderated it. “Our movements are not isolated, they have a common thread; students across the country have realised that people running corrupt education systems can be



Student activists at a press meet on AISA’s ‘GenZ on the rise’ convention, in New Delhi on Thursday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

questioned,” she said before introducing student activists from across States.

Among those on the panel was Shaikh Irshad Mansoori, the first identified to have pellet injuries in the July 20 Jantar Mantar march. “What happened was wrong. Students were unarmed when they attacked. Gen Z has united against what is going

wrong,” he said.

Voicing the issues faced by students in Jharkhand against paper leaks and irregularities in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission examinations, Habiba, a protester, said students had been struggling for years and the issue went beyond paper leaks. Alleging cor-

ruption and selling of seats, she said, “Gen Z will not be quiet. Gen Z has woken up... You might wonder ‘what will happen with one voice’, but it all starts with one voice.”

Manirathinam, the brother of Anitha, a medical aspirant who died by suicide in Tamil Nadu, spoke about continuing the fight for his sister and other students.

A student representative of IIT Delhi spoke about Rishikesh Kumar’s death, which led to protests on campus all through last week. Student representatives from NALSAR expressed solidarity via voice notes that were played during the convention.

(Those in distress can dial Tele MANAS helpline at 14416)

On Uttam Kumar’s birth centenary, Bengal CM vows to keep politics out of Tollywood

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Thursday said the government will leave politics out of the Bengali film industry while launching the birth centenary celebrations of late actor Uttam Kumar.

“I assure you that the State government will not interfere in anything. There will be no politics. I want everything to be transparent. There is talent and I want that talent to receive proper nourishment,” Mr. Adhikari said while addressing one of the largest gatherings to celebrate the event at Tollygunge, home to the Bengali film industry.

At the event, organised next to one of the tallest statues of Uttam Kumar in



CM Suwendu Adhikari addressing an event to pay tribute to actor Uttam Kumar on his birth centenary, in Kolkata on Thursday. ANI

the city, the CM said the Bengali film industry in its heyday was one of the best in the country. He added that renovation would be undertaken at institutions named after the actor as part of the celebrations.

Actor-turned-Trinamool Congress MP Dev (Deepak

Adhikari); actors Prosenjit Chatterjee, Rituparna Sengupta, and Jeet; and director Haranath Chakraborty were among the top artists present at the event.

During the tenure of the previous Trinamool Congress government, several artists and the party were

accused of “politicising” the Bengali film industry.

The government is holding a four-day celebration to commemorate the life and works of the actor popularly known as the ‘Mahanayak’ of Bengali cinema. Uttam Kumar was born on September 3, 1926 in north Kolkata and died aged 53 on July 24, 1980.

Kolkata was decked up on Thursday, with roads from the actor’s home to Tollygunge filled with murals, cut-outs, and cultural events to honour his contributions to the industry.

Film centre, stamp

Mr. Adhikari will lay the foundation stone for the Uttam Kumar Film Centre in New Town on Friday. India Post will also launch a special postage stamp commemorating the actor.

SIT to probe
Messi case,
says Kerala
Home Minister

The Hindu Bureau
IDUKKI

Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala has announced the formation of a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to probe the alleged financial misappropriation and tax evasion involving a failed bid to bring football legend Lionel Messi to the State.

“The team will conduct a detailed probe into the episode and submit a comprehensive report to the government immediately,” he said.

Mr. Chennithala added that the SIT was constituted based on a note received from the Chief Minister. “I sought a legal opinion from the Director-General of Prosecution and found several discrepancies in the incident.”

Telangana Minister dropped
from Cabinet on CM’s advice

Removal stems from remarks made by Surekha’s daughter against Revanth; appointment of Chinna Reddy as Vice-Chairman of Telangana Planning Board rescinded; new appointments announced

R. Ravikanth Reddy
HYDERABAD

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy on Thursday recommended that Governor Shiv Pratap Shukla remove Forest and Endowments Minister Konda Surekha from the Telangana Council of Ministers.

In a communication released at night, the Governor’s office said Ms. Surekha had been dropped from the Cabinet with immediate effect on the advice of the Chief Minister.

The release came after Mr. Revanth Reddy met the Governor at the Lok Bhan.

Sources said Ms. Surekha had refused to resign,



Sources say that Telangana Minister Konda Surekha, left, refused to resign, forcing the CM to recommend her removal. DEBOSRI MITRA

forcing the Chief Minister with the option of recommending her removal.

Ms. Surekha’s removal stems from recent comments by her daughter, Sushmitha, against the Chief Minister, and amid the political developments surrounding the Minister

over the last year. In a related development, the Chief Minister decided to rescind the appointment of G. Chinna Reddy as Vice-Chairman of the Telangana Planning Board.

Both decisions came after two-day deliberations with the party high com-

mand in New Delhi for discipline.

New appointments

The Chief Minister approved the appointment of Gadwal Vijayalakshmi as the new Vice-Chairman of the State Planning Board. He also approved the appointment of Nerella Sharada as Chairperson of the Telangana State Commission for Women. G. Sudha Rani, a former Rajya Sabha member, will be the Chairperson of the Kakatiya Urban Development Authority.

The fresh appointments appear to be aimed at countering criticism that a woman from the Backward Classes has been dropped from the Cabinet.

‘Regime suppressing youth will
have to answer to the people’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Accusing the Bihar government of using excessive force against protesting students, Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Thursday warned the BJP that any regime that suppresses the voice of the youth will eventually have to answer to the people.

Mr. Gandhi made his remarks after meeting students and young people from Bihar who, he said, had faced “horrific police brutality” while demanding fair opportunities, a transparent examination system, and their rights.

“Police lathis as well as gunfire from AK-47s and pistols left many students injured,” Mr. Gandhi said in



Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi interacting with students from Bihar, in New Delhi on Thursday. @RAHULGANDHI X

a post on X. He said that a young man aspiring to join the Army had suffered a leg injury from an AK-47 bullet, shattering his dream of serving the country.

Questioning the use of lathis and firearms against students, Mr. Gandhi said the government could not absolve itself of responsibility by blaming “a few low-ranking officials”. The police action, he said, was either the result of orders from

above or a sign of the “utter failure” of the administration.

He also extended his support to a Dalit girl who is seeking action against those who allegedly assaulted her father. In a post on X, he said she was being targeted for raising her voice for the rights of her community and students. He was responding to her plea for his help in registering a case with the Delhi police.

160 detonators found near Secunderabad Army camp

Naveen Kumar
HYDERABAD

Three days after the discovery of theft of service weapons and ammunition from the Madras Regiment premises in Bollaram, Secunderabad Cantonment, 160 electric detonators

were found near the Army camp on Wednesday. However, the police said the detonators were unrelated to the arms theft and were allegedly left behind during construction work beside the golf course.

The material was allegedly abandoned by un-

identified persons involved in the construction activity and was not connected to the theft of weapons from the Army premises.

Army personnel noticed a suspicious plastic bucket near the rear wall of the firing range and

alerted the police. Bollaram police, while inspecting the bucket, found 160 electric detonators packed in eight bundles. A bomb disposal team from Malkajgiri examined the material and identified it as 33A-size commercial electric detonators. Following the

team’s directions, the detonators were secured at a safe location.

The police have registered a case against unidentified persons in connection with the abandonment of the detonators and are investigating their source.

☀ Timings DELHI		
FRIDAY, SEP. 04		
☀ RISE	06:01	SET 18:39
☀ RISE	23:24	SET 13:10
SATURDAY, SEP. 05		
☀ RISE	06:01	SET 18:38
☀ RISE	00:00	SET 14:14
SUNDAY, SEP. 06		
☀ RISE	06:02	SET 18:37
☀ RISE	00:27	SET 15:14
Delhi Weather		
Delhi City	max 35	min 27
Safdarjang	35	27
Palam	32	24

Delhi Palam Today
33°C The weather will be warm. Chances of light rain and thundershower. Night will be comfortable.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
32°C The weather will be little warm. Spell of light to moderate rain and thundershower to occur. Night will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU

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North Eastern Railway
E-Tender Notice

Online open E-tenders are invited by Senior Divisional Electrical Engineer/ TRS/Electric Loco Shed/Gorakhpur/ North Eastern Railway, acting for and on behalf of the President of India for the following work:

Tender Notice No. & Description -
Tender Notice No. : ELS-GKP-SLAM-2026-27R "Management of SLAM System at ELS-GKP for 2 years", Estimated Cost : ₹ 56,48,283.08, Earnest Money : ₹ 1,13,000.00, Cost of Tender Form : ₹ 00.00, Contract Period: 24 Months.

• Offer can be uploaded by the tenderer, up to 15:00 Hrs. on 29.09.2026 and will be opened after 15:00 Hrs. on 29.09.2026. • Detailed information, minimum eligibility criteria, Terms and conditions regarding this e-tender are available at website www.ireps.gov.in.

• Tenderer should check any correction/corrigendum related to this e-tender notice on the website before uploading their offer.

DEE/TRS, N.E. Railway, Electric Loco Shed/ CPPO/Elect-169 Gorakhpur

Do not travel with inflammable article in train

PUNE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
CHIEF ENGINEER DEPARTMENT
NOTICE INVITING TENDERS (N.I.T.) YEAR-2025-26

Tender No.	Name of Department	Name of work	Cost of Tender Document (Rs.)	Estimated Cost (Rs.)	EMD Amount Rs.	Work Period (Month)	Concern Contact Person
PMC/ ROAD/ 2026/ 242	Road	प्र.क्र. २४ ड, पदमजी पार्क, पदमजी कंपाउंड येथील परिसरत विविध ठिकाणी रस्ते विकसित करणे व तदनुषंगिक कामे करणे.	Rs.17879/-	Rs. 57572521/-	Rs.287862.5/-	15	Rohan Rajendra Hatte 9639391515

A) All details of Terms & Conditions of above works are incorporated in tender documents which is available on website www.mahatenders.gov.in Sale & acceptance is available by online system only. Tender needs to be submit in two envelope format.
B) If sales or submission not been available on last day also & it is not been submitted will be sole responsible of tenderer.
C) Online tender process information will be available at Road, Pune Muncipal Corporation.
D) As per office order No. 32, dated 22/04/2016 EMD deposit amount will be acceptable through ECS/RTGS/NEFT Online Banking Only.

सही /-
कार्यकारी अभियंता
कार्यालय (पथ)
पुणे महानगरपालिका

ADVT No: 3/709, Date:- 03/09/2026

LEGAL NOTICE
IN THE GAUHATI HIGH COURT
(THE HIGH COURT OF ASSAM, NAGALAND, MIZORAM AND ARUNACHAL PRADESH)
(CIVIL EXTRA-ORDINARY JURISDICTION)
W.P(C) No. 2283/2025

Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti PETITIONER
-versus-
Yogesh Kumar RESPONDENTS

To:
Sri Yogesh Kumar,
Son of Shri Rajinder Singh,
Resident of Government Boys Higher Secondary School,
Bhorgarh, P.O. Bhorgarh Delhi,
District - North West Delhi, Delhi- 110040.

"Whereas the above named petitioner has preferred the aforementioned writ petition challenging the order dated 20.12.2024 passed by the Hon'ble CAT, Guwahati Bench in O.A. No. 204/2024 and the case has been fixed on 09.09.2026.
You are hereby informed to appear either personally or through your engaged counsel before this Hon'ble Court upon receipt of this Notice.
Take notice that if you fail to appear and show cause as directed, the matter shall be heard and decided ex-parte, in your absence.
Given under my hand and seal, on this 2nd day of September, 2026 at Guwahati.

Deputy Registrar
Gauhati High Court
Guwahati-781001

BEFORE THE HONOURABLE DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL I ERNAKULAM
ORIGINAL APPLICATION No. 568 of 2025

South Indian Bank, Kasaragod Branch : Applicant
Vs
M/s Suvidya Printers and Publishers Pvt Ltd and Ors : Defendants

SUMMONS

Whereas, OA No. 568/2025 was listed before the Tribunal on 07.08.2026
Whereas, this Hon'ble Tribunal is pleased to issue Summons/ on the said application under Section 19(4) of the Act, filed against you for recovery of debts of Rs. 2,93,04,390.42/-
In Accordance with Sub-Section (4) of Section 19 of the Act, you the defendants 4 are directed as under.
(i) To show cause within thirty days of the service of summons as to why relief prayed for should not be granted;
(ii) To disclose particulars of properties or assets other than properties and assets specified by the applicant under 3A of the original application;
(iii) You are restrained from dealing with or disposing of secured assets or such other assets and properties disclosed under serial number 3A of the original application, pending hearing and disposal of the application for attachment of properties;
(iv) You shall not transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise, except in the ordinary course of his business any of the assets over which security interest is created and/or other assets and properties specified or disclosed under serial number 3A of the original application without the prior approval of the Tribunal;
(v) You shall be liable to account for the sale proceeds realized by sale of secured assets or other assets and properties in the ordinary course of business and deposit such sale proceeds in the account maintained with the bank or financial institutions holding security interest over such assets.
You are also directed to file the written statement with a copy thereof furnished to the applicant and to appear before the Registrar of this Tribunal on 28.09.2026 at 11.00 a.m failing which the Application shall be heard and decided in your absence.
Given under my hand and seal of the Tribunal on this 28th day of August, 2026

Sd/-, Registrar, Debts Recovery Tribunal, Ernakulam

Defendants 3 to 9

3. Jinu Manoj, W/o Manoj Cheruvil, Proprietor, M/s Vidya Book House, Residing at Cheruvil House, Chunda P O, Cherupuzha via, Kannur-670 511
4. Shaji V George, Raghuvansi-11 Colony, Gandhi Ward No 12, Behind Chhange, Raju Petrol Pump, Mohan Nivas, Panna, Madhyapradesh, PIN 488 001
5. Shaju Joseph, S/o C K Joseph, Mahaveva, Pateli, Smartan Social Service Society, Satna, Madhya Pradesh, PIN 485 001
6. Achamma Joseph Alias Thersamma Joseph, Cheruvil Sevense, Chunda P O, Pulingome, Cherupuzha, Kannur-670 511
7. Biju P Devasia, Puthusseryil Meenthulli, Kozhichal P O, Pulingome, Cherupuzha, Kannur-PIN 670 511
8. Siji V Shaji Alias Thersia Cheruvil, Raghuvansi-11 Colony, Gandhi Ward No 12, Behind Chhange, Raju Petrol Pump, Mohan Nivas, Panna, Madhyapradesh, PIN 488 001
9. Rejenga Joseph, Puthusseryil Meenthulli, Kozhichal P O, Pulingome, Cherupuzha, Kannur-PIN 670 511, Kasargod, Kerala, PIN-671 124.

Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER PMGSY (JKRRDA) JAMMU.
NOTICE INVITING e-TENDERS
e-NIT No.-CEJ/PMGSY/ 841 of 2026-27 Dated:- 01/09/2026

Chief Engineer PMGSY (JKRRDA) Jammu on behalf of The Government of Jammu & Kashmir, invites e-tenders on %age Above/Excess (+) OR %age Below/ Less (-) basis (i.e. on Percentage-Rate Basis) from approved and eligible Contractors registered with J&K U.T.Govt. CPWD, Railways or equivalent and other State/U.T.Govts up to 1700 Hrs. on 17-09-2026 for each of the following works.

S. No.	Name of the Work/Package. No.	Name of the PU	Consent Part (Rs. in Lacs)	Maint Part (Rs. in Lacs)	Total (Rs. in Lacs)	Cost of documents (Rs. in Lacs)	Bid Security (EMD) (0.2% of total cost rounded to the nearest thousand (Rs. in Lacs)	Time Allowed for completion	Call of tender	Time and date of opening of tenders	Class of contractor
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
1	Construction and Maintenance of Road from L026- (Link Road) Nadi Talab to Khandra Package No. JK14-4031- PMGSY-IV, Batch-I of 2026-27, Block-Tikri, District Udhampur. (Using Waste Plastics 5,200 Kms) Length 5,200 Kms Adv. Cost excluding maintenance but inclusive of GST-Rs. 1174.51 Lacs	Udhampur	1174.51	93.96	1268.47	0.20	25.37	15 months	2nd	19-09-2026 1100 Hrs.	Any registered contractor with State/U.T. PWD/CPWD / Railways or equivalent qualifying eligibility criteria as provided in the Standard Bidding Documents can tender for the works
2	Construction and Maintenance of Road from L104-(Link Road) Barmeen to Dhamoo Km 12th to Barshalian Package No. JK14-4039- PMGSY-IV, Batch-I of 2026-27, Block-Chhori, District Udhampur (Using Waste Plastics 7,350 Kms) Length 7,350 Kms Adv. Cost excluding maintenance but inclusive of GST-Rs. 1741.52 Lacs	Udhampur	1741.52	139.32	1880.84	0.20	37.62	18 months	2nd		

Date and Time Schedule

S.No	Particulars	Date	Time
1.	Date of issue of tender notice	01-09-2026	1700 hrs
2.	Document Download / Sale Start Date	03-09-2026	1855 hrs
3.	Pre-Bid Meeting	05-09-2026	1200 hrs
4.	Bid Submission Start Date	07-09-2026	1000 hrs
5.	Bid Submission End Date	17-09-2026	1700 hrs
6.	Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bids	19-09-2026	1100 hrs
7.	Date & Time of Opening of Financial Bids	To be notified after technical evaluation is completed	

1. The bidding document can be downloaded from the website and bids shall be submitted ONLINE ONLY in electronic form through the e-tendering portal.
2. For complete details and instructions, bidders are advised to refer to Standard bidding document (SBD).
3. For further details and updates, bidders may visit the official website <https://pmgsytendersjk.gov.in>

No-CEJ/PMGSY/18346+18420
Dated:-01-09-2026

Sd/-
Chief Engineer PMGSY (JKRRDA) Jammu
For and on behalf of The Government of Jammu and Kashmir

DIP/J-9290/26

J&K Bank
Serving To Empower

Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited
Technology & Development.
Fifth Floor, Corporate headquarters
M.A Road, Srinagar 190001

Expression of Interest from Technology Partners / Solution Providers / OEMs for Evaluation of the Proposition of Developing an Agentic AI & Generative AI (GenAI) Enablement Platform, alongside Assessment of the Feasibility of Deploying a Private Large Language Model (LLM) — on Public Cloud or On -Premises — together with Indicative Costing Structures for Development, Fine-Tuning, Hosting and Ongoing Token Usage-Based Consumption

EOI Notice along with Complete EOI document outlining the minimum requirements can be downloaded from and BIDs can be submitted on the Banks' e-Tendering Portal <https://jkbank.abcpurchase.com> w.e.f. September 02, 2026, 16.00 Hrs. Tender Document can also be downloaded from Bank's Official Website <https://jkb.bank.in/>. Last date for submission of Bids is September 24, 2026 17.00 Hrs.
e-EOI Ref No JKB/CHQ/T&D/LLM-Evaluation/2026-1880
Dated : 02-09-2026

Registered office : Corporate Headquarters, M.A.Road, Srinagar 190001, Kashmir, India
CIN: L65110 JK193656C000048 ; T : +91 (0)194 248 930-35 ; F : +91 (0)194 248 1928;
E : info@jkbmail.com ; W : <https://jkb.bank.in>

APPOINTMENTS

चौ. शिवनाथ शॉण्डिल्य पी.जी. कालिज माछरा (मेरठ)

आवश्यकता हे पुस्तकालय सहायक, एक पद अनारक्षित, आयु सीमा 18 से 40 वर्ष, अनिवार्य योग्यता इण्टरमीडिएट के साथ भारत सरकार/ राज्य सरकार द्वारा मान्यता प्राप्त संस्था से पुस्तकालय विज्ञान में 06 माह का प्रमाण पत्र एवं कंप्यूटर संचालन में डोयक सोसायटी (DOEACC) परिवर्तित नाम नाइलैट द्वारा प्रवर्त सी सी सी. प्रमाणपत्र अथवा समकक्ष स्तर का प्रमाण पत्र। (शासनदेश सं -19/ 2015/ 581/ सतर-2-2015-16 (645)/ 201 दिनांक 03 नवम्बर 2015 के अनुसार) वेतनमान वेतन बैंड -1, लेवल-3, रुपये 5200-20200 एवं ग्रेड वेतन रु. 2000 आवेदन पत्र महाविद्यालय में इस विज्ञापन के प्रकाशन की तिथि से 21 दिन के अन्दर सचिव, प्रबन्ध समिति, चौ. शिवनाथ शॉण्डिल्य पी.जी. कालिज माछरा (मेरठ) को केवल पंजीकृत डाक से ही उपलब्ध कराया। आवेदन पत्र में अभ्यर्थी का नाम, पिता का नाम, माता का नाम, श्रेणी, जन्म तिथि, स्थाई पता, पत्र व्यवहार का पता, मोबाईल नं., शैक्षिक योग्यता, एवं कार्य अनुभव का उल्लेख हो। आवेदन पत्र पर फोटो भी चिपका हो, आधारकार्ड एवं प्रमाणपत्रों की स्वयं हस्ताक्षरित छाया प्रति संलग्न हो। उपरोक्त पद हेतु योग्यता उ.प्र. सरकार द्वारा एवं विश्वविद्यालय के अधिनियम के विभिन्न आदेशों के अनुसार होगी। साक्षात्कार हेतु यात्रा भत्ता एवं अन्य कोई भत्ता देय नहीं होगा। साक्षात्कार दिनांक 04.10.2026 को प्रातः 09 बजे से महाविद्यालय प्राचार्य कार्यालय में प्रारम्भ होगा।

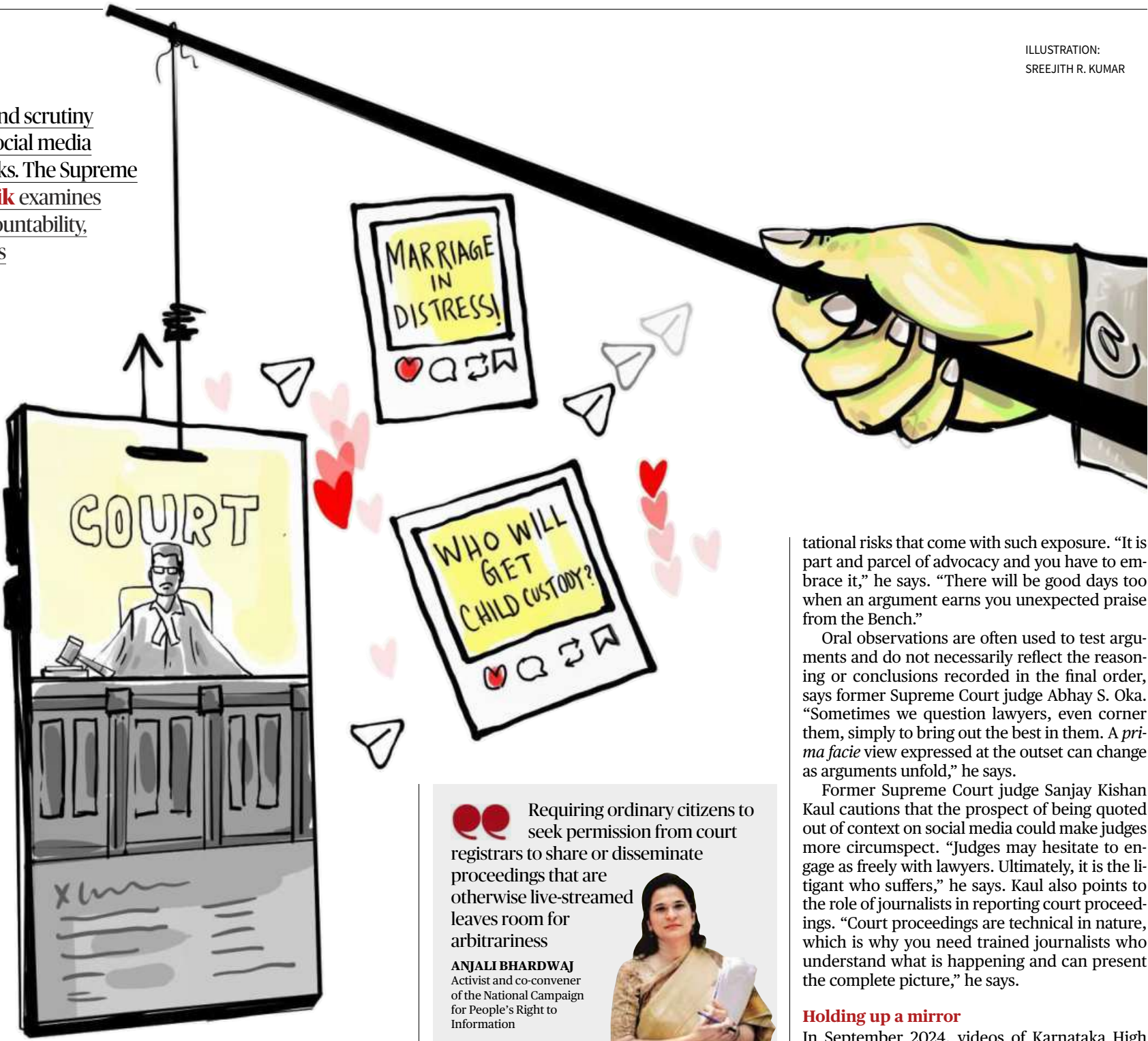
प्राचार्य सचिव

SPOTLIGHT

Live-streaming and virtual hearings have brought transparency and scrutiny to courtrooms. But footage is often snipped and uploaded onto social media platforms, sometimes stripped of context and repackaged for clicks. The Supreme Court has moved to restrict their circulation. **Aaratrika Bhaumik** examines what the interim order could mean for public access, judicial accountability, and the youth, which is accustomed to consuming bite-sized news

Courtroom
dramas,
clipped
and shared

ILLUSTRATION:
SREEJITH R. KUMAR



From her room in a town in Assam, Tanisha Som, 24, would spend hours watching courtrooms, hundreds of kilometres away, come to life on her screen. She would watch women lawyers command the courtroom, threading their arguments through a thicket of questions from the Bench, pressing an argument here and conceding there, until even the most sceptical judges began to come around. At the time, becoming a lawyer seemed a dream. She had little sense of what went on behind the soaring columns and heavy wooden doors of an institution that seemed built as much to inspire awe as to keep outsiders out.

Then in 2022, the Supreme Court began live-streaming proceedings before its Constitutional Benches. These Benches comprise five or more judges deciding substantial questions concerning the interpretation of the Constitution.

“Until then, much of what I knew about courtrooms came from Bollywood movies. Live-streamed proceedings and courtroom clips gave me a window into how courts actually function. For the first time, I could picture myself on the other side of the screen – inside one of those courtrooms, in a black robe,” she says.

Nearly three years ago, Som made it to her dream law school. Despite the gruelling schedule of a national law university, court proceedings remained a part of her day. She would sit through Constitution Bench hearings on YouTube or stumble upon courtroom clips on Instagram, wedged between memes and viral dance trends.

“These video clips instilled in me a passion for advocacy and helped me understand courcraft. It is not something you can really learn within the four walls of a classroom,” she says.

But the clips that gave Som an early glimpse into the profession are now at the centre of a larger debate: while they have brought transparency and scrutiny to courtrooms, exchanges between judges and lawyers can also be clipped out of context and circulated for sensationalism.

Harshita Grover, a journalist, recently moved the Supreme Court asking for restrictions on circulation of courtroom clips on digital platforms. She pointed out that many were distorted and stripped of context.

On July 24, the Supreme Court, in an interim order, barred the use and circulation of audio and video clips of judicial proceedings on social media and other digital platforms without prior permission from court registrars.

A Bench led by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said “isolated excerpts” risked “trivialising” the administration of justice. The next hearing of the case is scheduled for September 18.

The court later clarified that “recognised news outlets” could continue reporting on proceedings, but could not “utilise” audio or video clips. However, it did not define the term “recognised news outlets”, leaving some confusion among those who report on court proceedings, especially independent journalists. While it considers a broader protocol, the court has added other stakeholders to the proceedings. These include High Courts and social media intermediaries, including Meta, LinkedIn, and X Corp.

The unfettered access Som enjoyed was elusive when Swapnil Tripathi, 29, was a law student nearly eight years ago. While interning with a Supreme Court lawyer, he spent weeks working on a case of constitutional importance, only to miss the hearing because interns were allowed inside the court only on certain days to prevent overcrowding.

“I was very disheartened. I had worked closely on the case and wanted to see how the arguments played out,” he recalls. But conversations with litigants soon made him realise that the institutional barriers to accessing courtrooms were not limited to law students. “Litigants would travel to Delhi from remote corners of the country, often for cases that could alter the course of their lives. Yet, many could not even enter the courtroom because of overcrowding,” he says.

Tripathi soon moved the Supreme Court seeking live-streaming of cases of constitutional importance. In September 2018, his petition culminated in a landmark ruling recognising live-streaming as part of the right to access justice under Article 21 of the Constitution. Underlining that “sunlight is the best disinfectant”, Justice D.Y. Chandrachud reasoned that the public’s right to know how justice is administered is integral to a functioning democracy.

Virtual hearing links are often shared indiscriminately beyond litigants and lawyers. So even when High Courts pause live-streaming for sensitive cases, people logged into the virtual hearing can record the proceedings

SWAPNIL TRIPATHI
Head of Charkha (Centre for Constitutional Law) at the Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy, a think tank



nistered is integral to a functioning democracy. The court also urged High Courts to gradually introduce live-streaming while framing rules to govern its use.

Letting the sunlight in

In March 2026, Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal told the Lok Sabha that live-streaming was operational in 11 High Courts. The Supreme Court’s official YouTube channel has now amassed over 2.67 lakh subscribers, with major Constitution Bench proceedings available to anyone with a screen and an Internet connection. A video of its *suo motu* hearing in the R.G. Kar rape-murder case, uploaded in September 2024, has been viewed nearly 48,000 times – an audience that could never have squeezed into a physical courtroom. This is one of the rare instances when a rape case was live-streamed on the apex court’s YouTube channel.

Although the Supreme Court has 17 functioning courtrooms, it largely live-streams only Constitution Bench hearings, which are held intermittently. In contrast, High Courts such as Gujarat, Karnataka, and Calcutta live-stream proceedings daily from a majority of their courtrooms. Gujarat became the first High Court to formally go live on YouTube in July 2021 and its channel now has nearly 1.97 lakh subscribers.

Live streams are not the only source of courtroom footage online. The Supreme Court and High Courts also allow lawyers and litigants to join hearings virtually through platforms such as Cisco Webex, with links often made available through daily cause lists. Clips from these proceedings, too, have found their way onto social media, including from sensitive matters involving sexual offences, matrimonial disputes, and child custody.

Tripathi, who now heads Charkha (Centre for Constitutional Law) at the Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy, a think tank, says the 2018 judgment anticipated some of the concerns being flagged today. “Safeguards were built in from the beginning,” he says, pointing out that matrimonial and sexual assault cases and proceedings involving children and juveniles were excluded from live-streaming. The Supreme Court e-Committee’s Model Rules released in 2021, he notes, also prohibit unauthorised dissemination and use of courtroom footage for commercial, promotional, or advertising purposes.

Requiring ordinary citizens to seek permission from court registrars to share or disseminate proceedings that are otherwise live-streamed leaves room for arbitrariness

ANJALI BHARDWAJ
Activist and co-convenor of the National Campaign for People’s Right to Information



Court proceedings are technical in nature, which is why you need trained journalists who understand what is happening and can present the complete picture

SANJAY KISHAN KAUL
Former Supreme Court Judge



“However, what we are seeing now is that virtual hearing links are often shared indiscriminately beyond litigants and lawyers,” he says.

“So even when High Courts pause live-streaming for sensitive cases, people logged into the virtual hearing can record the proceedings and put them on social media despite rules prohibiting unauthorised recording,” he adds.

Anjali Bhardwaj, activist and co-convenor of the National Campaign for People’s Right to Information, says the interim order marks a shift towards a permission regime. “Requiring ordinary citizens to seek permission from court registrars to share or disseminate proceedings that are otherwise live-streamed leaves room for arbitrariness,” she says. “There is no clarity on how permission is to be sought, the grounds for granting or denying it, or the recourse available if it is refused.” Acknowledging the risk of clips being taken out of context, Bhardwaj suggests that a better safeguard could be to expand live-streaming and archiving of proceedings on authorised platforms instead of restricting their circulation. “A complete, official record acts as a deterrent and allows manipulated clips to be readily exposed.”

A courtroom in your feed

A netizen may now swipe past holiday photos, influencer reels, and courtroom scenes with the same detached ease. Controversial matrimonial cases can draw over 1 lakh views. Sometimes, lawyers use a judge’s remark to leverage their social media following.

In July 2026, the Bar Council of India issued a circular prohibiting reels and promotional content from court premises. It also directed State Bar Councils to designate social media ethics nodal officers to deal with complaints and lawyers to submit a signed undertaking at the time of enrolment pledging to maintain professional conduct on social media.

“Matrimonial and custody cases generally draw the most attention on social media,” says Ravitosh Dubey, founder of legal news portal *LawChakra*. “Someone going through a divorce, for instance, would be curious to see how courts approach such cases, the questions judges ask, and how the process unfolds,” he says.

Since the interim order, *LawChakra* has largely shifted to explanatory videos without courtroom footage. Clips that accurately represent court proceedings should not be restricted, Dubey says. At *LawChakra*, edits were limited to trimming pauses and removing litigants’ personal details. “I have consciously refrained from publishing heated exchanges between the Bench and the Bar when, viewed in isolation, they could misrepresent what transpired in court.”

The proliferation of courtroom clips has also brought lawyers under scrutiny. They are increasingly aware that their clients may be watching. “You cannot simply seek unnecessary adjournments,” says Supreme Court advocate Lavkesh Bhambhani. “To earn your fee, you have to satisfy the client that you have done justice to their case.”

Bhambhani, however, is unfazed by the reputational risks that come with such exposure. “It is part and parcel of advocacy and you have to embrace it,” he says. “There will be good days too when an argument earns you unexpected praise from the Bench.”

Oral observations are often used to test arguments and do not necessarily reflect the reasoning or conclusions recorded in the final order, says former Supreme Court judge Abhay S. Oka. “Sometimes we question lawyers, even corner them, simply to bring out the best in them. A *prima facie* view expressed at the outset can change as arguments unfold,” he says.

Former Supreme Court judge Sanjay Kishan Kaul cautions that the prospect of being quoted out of context on social media could make judges more circumspect. “Judges may hesitate to engage as freely with lawyers. Ultimately, it is the litigant who suffers,” he says. Kaul also points to the role of journalists in reporting court proceedings. “Court proceedings are technical in nature, which is why you need trained journalists who understand what is happening and can present the complete picture,” he says.

Holding up a mirror
In September 2024, videos of Karnataka High Court judge Justice Vedavyasachar Srishananda sparked furore online. He was seen in one video referring to a Muslim-dominated locality in west Bengaluru as “Pakistan” and making a sexist remark to a woman lawyer in another.

Within days, a Supreme Court Bench led by then CJI D.Y. Chandrachud took *suo motu* cognisance, cautioning judges against making “casual observations” reflecting communal bias or misogyny. The judge later apologised and the proceedings were closed. More recently, CJI Kant’s reported reference to “cockroaches” during a hearing on fake law degrees drew widespread criticism and spawned the Cockroach Janta Party, which went on to spearhead protests against examination paper leaks. CJI Kant later said his remarks had been “misquoted” by the media.

Oral observations by judges are crucial to report despite having no binding value, says Manu Sebastian, managing editor of legal news portal *LiveLaw*. “They offer an insight into judicial thinking and hold a mirror to the institution. The response should be introspection, not clamping down on public scrutiny or reportage,” he says.

He points to the Supreme Court’s 2021 ruling in *Chief Election Commissioner vs M.R. Vijayabhaskar*, which protected the reporting of oral remarks and stressed the role of public scrutiny in ensuring institutional accountability.

Sebastian adds that the exemption for “recognised news outlets” could favour established media organisations over citizen journalists and smaller newsrooms. He sees little justification for permitting written accounts of courtroom exchanges while prohibiting video clips that faithfully reproduce them.

“AI-generated or doctored videos should be prohibited. But faithful reporting, regardless of the medium, should be permitted,” he says.

The risk of misreporting, Justice Oka notes, predates the social media age. “I remember being misquoted by a trainee print journalist when I was a Bombay High Court judge,” he says.

“Oral remarks can be misreported or sensationalised in newspaper reports too. But as long as judges confine themselves to the merits of the case, that should not deter them from speaking their minds,” he adds.

Pointing to a rapidly evolving media ecosystem, legal scholar Alok Prasanna Kumar says courts must adapt to changing news consumption habits. “Allowing an oral exchange to be reported in print while restricting its dissemination through video clips is at odds with how people consume news today,” he says. “It is a bit like trying to stop the wind from blowing.”

A March 2026 report by the Reuters Institute, which facilitates programmes to promote the practice and analysis of journalism, captures the shift. It states that people in the 18 to 24 age group citing social media as their main source of news rose from 21% in 2015 to 39% in 2025, overtaking news websites and apps. The report also describes young audiences as increasingly “social-first”, with much of their news consumption incidental rather than intentional.

Any new restrictions should follow wide-ranging consultation, says former Supreme Court judge Madan B. Lokur. “A unilateral decision is never welcome. Any institutional reform should involve all High Courts and stakeholders.”

Som, now in her final months of law school, will soon don the black robes she once dreamt of. But she remains wary of depending on traditional media to tell her what happens inside a courtroom. “The judiciary wields enormous power over our lives. I don’t want a sanitised version of how that power is exercised,” she says.

“I would rather see what happened and decide for myself.”

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Across much of India, the monsoon brings a seasonal pause to wildlife tourism, with many national parks and reserves restricting access to their core areas during the rains. For travellers staying at eco-lodges and resorts, this makes the season particularly rewarding for guided Nature walks, where the focus shifts to observing a landscape transformed by the rains.

For Manav Khanduja, co-founder, Pugdundee Safaris, the appeal of the monsoon lies in this altered field of attention. The company operates wildlife lodges across Central India.

Around grasslands, wetlands and agricultural edges, baya weavers become absorbed in one of the season's most elaborate construction projects. Male baya weavers cut and carry strips of grass and plant fibre, knotting and weaving them into pendulous nests that hang from palms, acacias and other trees, often near water.

Around wetlands, painted storks can gather where water levels and feeding conditions are favourable. In wooded areas, Indian pittas, Asian paradise flycatchers and adult black-naped monarchs build nests or carry food to hatchlings.

Around Pugdundee's central Indian lodges, you may also

check

At naturalist-led trails across Indian wildlife lodges, the monsoon shifts focus to breeding frogs, nesting birds, fruiting fungi and other smaller lives

encounter fungoid frogs, skittering frogs, termite-hill frogs and, less commonly, balloon frogs, too.

On a productive walk, Manav says, the property's naturalists may record seven or eight frog species. Nature walks are chargeable and start at ₹1,500 per person.

Into the wild

Farther South, in Karnataka, The Serai's Bandipur and Kabini properties offer guided Nature walks through their monsoon landscapes. June to September is particularly rewarding at Kabini, while June and July bring a lush, rain-washed forest to Bandipur.

According to Sreekantha, senior naturalist, The Serai Bandipur, the broad impressions of Asian elephant feet, the hoofprints of Indian gaur and, occasionally, leopard pugmarks allow naturalists to interpret wildlife movement even

when the animals themselves remain out of sight.

Among the birds Sreekantha identifies during the season are the Malabar pied hornbill, crested serpent eagle, Indian peafowl, red spurfowl and pied cuckoo.

At Kabini, water becomes the organising force of the landscape.

"Egrets and herons work the shallows; painted storks gather around suitable wetlands; kingfishers wait above the water; and cormorants and river terns move along the river," says Chamaraj, senior naturalist, The Serai Kabini.

Guided Nature walks at Serai Resorts are included with every stay.

One with Nature

Farther West in Madhya Pradesh, the monsoon settles differently over the Satpura landscape. At Bori Safari Lodge, guided walks take place

Mackerel sky (Clockwise from left) A Nature enthusiast; Malabar pit viper; bioluminescent fungi; Indian bullfrog; giant Malabar squirrel; and Nilgiri langur. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



within and around the lodge grounds, along designated trails and, where permissions allow, in adjoining buffer landscapes. The birdlife offers one way of reading the changing season. Tickell's blue flycatchers occupy shaded woodland and streamside vegetation. Indian golden orioles, crested serpent eagles and grey-headed fish eagles add flashes of yellow or movement above the canopy.

Lime butterflies, common Mormons and common Jezebels move through flowering vegetation. Shield bugs appear in colours that can seem almost enamelled while jewel beetles catch the light in metallic greens.

At Bori, guided Nature walks and the other activities included in the monsoon programme are part of the room tariff.

When night falls

At Wayanad Wild, CGH Earth's Nature lodge in the forested hills of northern Kerala, the night trail introduces a different set of reptiles, says David Raju, lodge manager, Wayanad Wild. One may encounter venomous Malabar pit vipers and the Malabar vine snake.

During prolonged wet spells, bioluminescent fungi produce light through a chemical reaction within their tissues. For David, all these encounters form part of a wholesome experience.

"Stories stay with guests far longer," he says.

STEPOUT



Art unbound

Artistic freedom takes centrestage in Sing. No Cry, a group exhibition bringing together nine artists whose practices follow instinct and experimentation. Curated by Jasone Miranda-Bilbao and Vaibhav Raj Shah, the show draws on the spirit of David Lynch's film *Wild at Heart* to explore what happens when artists resist familiar structures and trust their own impulses. *On view until October 15 at Thapar Contemporary, The One, Kapashera Estate, Rajokri Crossing.*



Lush landscapes

The traditional Kerala idea of 'kani' — the auspicious first sight of beauty and abundance — shapes Roy K John's latest body of work. Combining Kerala mural painting techniques with contemporary approaches, the artist reimagines orchards, groves, and botanical forms through layered compositions and rich colour. Recent wooden leaf sculptures extend this exploration into three dimensions. *Curated by Satyajit Dave, the exhibition opens on September 6 and runs until September 10, from 11am to 7pm, at Bikaner House.*

The last song

Abandoned reveals an artist whose practice was shaped equally by labour and keen observation



Legacy in stone
Latika Katt's work reveals the gentler side of the fiercely independent artist. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Shailaja Tripathi

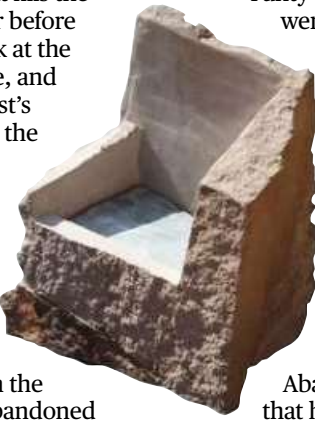
"I wanted visitors to feel they had met her. To feel the hands that chiselled these rocks, and to leave with an experience that stays."

That is how Tuntty Chauhan of Gallery Threshold describes its latest show, *Abandoned* — an exhibition of sculptor Latika Katt's final body of work. After walking through the show, it is difficult to disagree with Tuntty.

There is a stillness that fills the gallery. You pause longer before each work, carefully look at the impressions on the stone, and begin to imagine the artist's hands at work. A film on the artist by Muzaffar Ali playing on loop in the gallery makes one even more curious.

Latika, who passed away in 2025, spent a lifetime carving stone, casting bronze, and pushing boundaries with the medium of sculpture. *Abandoned* showcases the works Latika made during the last few years of her life, alongside a few intimate graphite drawings.

Bronze forms, first cast in wax, have been embedded into blocks of stone.



The works look almost like fragments unearthed from an archaeological excavation, part relic, part architecture, and part memory. The sculptures are grounded in ideas that occupied Latika throughout her career. She was fascinated by Nature, erosion, growth, weathering and decay.

Latika once said, "My sculptures are about my feelings to what touches my heart and mind." Her graphite drawings capture light falling on water, tree branches, and shifting landscapes.

Tuntty says that Latika's drawings were intensely personal. "They reveal the gentler side of this fiercely independent woman."

Born in Varanasi in 1948, Latika belonged to a generation when very few women chose sculpture as a profession. She became an eminent sculptor, working across stone, marble, bronze, terracotta, paper, and even cow dung.

Abandoned is a poignant show that hints at the transient nature of life.

Abandoned is on view at Gallery Threshold, C-221, Sarvodaya Enclave, till September 12.



Sound check (Left) Singer-rapper Baby Jean; (inset) Shobana at the festival. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

performance. Shobana, who performed at South Side Story last year, said that her experience had been wonderful and she did not think twice before giving her nod of approval for this year's shows in Pune and Delhi. "If a platform like South Side Story allows someone in Delhi to watch a South Indian classical dance performance for the first time and leave with an interest in knowing more about it, then that is already a meaningful contribution to the growth of the art," said the dancer.

Bringing the exciting evening to an energetic finish were Masala Coffee and Thaikudam Bridge. A combination of rock, funk and rooted sounds, Masala Coffee debuted on the South Side Story stage and were admittedly "awe-struck by Delhi's energy".

And then came the band that has been a part of all eight editions of South Side Story — the multi-genre Thaikudam Bridge took over with its soundscape built upon elements of folk and classical sounds, interspersed with layers of progressive, pop, ambient, and electronic textures.

Over the course of these two days, the audience also got to experience the many textures of South Indian culture through kalaripayattu, chenda and dhol, Bharatanatyam and Kathakali showcases, alongside Onam sadya and a selection of curated food and beverage experiences. Nisha Narayanan, director-COO, Red FM, says, "This energy is difficult to match, and it makes us feel even more responsible towards representing all communities and cultures."

The Hindu is the print partner for South Side Story 2026

All roads lead South

From Baby Jean's hip-hop to Shobana's Bharatanatyam, this edition of South Side Story brought the pulse of the peninsula to Delhi

Deepali Dhingra

Where else would you see fluid sarees paired with sneakers, crisp veshtis complementing brightly coloured shirts, and traditional gajras effortlessly styled with sleek sunglasses? Spanning two high-energy days in Delhi, Red FM initiative South Side Story 2026 brought together over 13,000 attendees across generations and geographies for a rich celebration of South Indian music, art, and culinary heritage.

Day one saw rising rapper Baby Jean of Kerala open the festival with his signature wordplay and infectious beats, singing tracks such as 'Taporì', 'Pantal Chant', and 'Neon Ride'. The Raghu Dixit Project, which is celebrating its 25th anniversary this year, kickstarted its performance with the

popular 'Parasiva' and went on to regale the crowd with hits such as 'Jag Changa', 'Shakkarpari' and the rock anthem 'Neene Beku', taking time to explain the meaning of each song. A musical jugalbandi between its flautist, violinist, and guitarists was one of the highlights of its performance.

Known for singing his brand of 'happy music', Raghu said, "Going on stage and infusing a little joy and positivity into people has become first nature for me now, and my music has found its purpose doing that."

As the evening progressed, Sooraj Santhosh delivered a soulful set, culminating in a massive crowd

sing-along to 'Kaantha'. Closing out the night, Karthik brought explosive energy to the stage, charming the audience with hits like 'Oru Maalai', 'Vizhi Moodi', and the melodious 'Aye Sinamika'. Singer Arya Dhayal captivated the crowd with a versatile set, shouting "Love you, Delhi!" between



chartbusters, while Malayalam hip-hop artist Aksomaniac seamlessly glided between smooth melodies and high-tempo beats. The audience had been waiting with bated breath to watch Padma Bhushan awardee Shobana, and their wish was fulfilled as the Bharatanatyam dancer left them mesmerised with her graceful



Welcome move

The relief granted to the Gen Z protesters must not stop with them

In what should be termed a salutary gesture, the Supreme Court of India, at the request of the Union government, invoked its powers under Article 142 of the Constitution to quash criminal cases against the youth who had taken part in nationwide protests seeking examination reforms and government accountability. Led by a group, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), in response to Chief Justice of India’s “unemployment” and “cockroaches” remark – these protests swelled in numbers and reach, forcing the then Union Minister of Education, Dharmendra Pradhan, to resign. Among the demands for halting the agitations was the CJP’s call to withdraw the FIRs against protesters in Delhi and other States/Union Territories, which the Court has granted, while directing the Centre to ensure that no fresh FIRs are registered over the protests in July. That the Centre asked for this step by the Court shows how the CJP’s agitations resonated with the youth of the country, who agreed with the movement’s core demands. It is also an acknowledgment by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led government that this is a pressing issue that revealed its failings, particularly the series of paper leaks across India over the years, compounded by an employment deficit for youth.

The Centre’s stand in the CJP matter is in stark contrast to how it has dealt with dissent on other issues that have driven thousands to protest in recent years. The most prominent among these were the farmer-led protests in and around Delhi, and the agitations against the communally motivated Citizenship (Amendment) Act. Both were largely peaceful, but this did not prevent the government from foisting serious charges including those related to terrorism and sedition, on peaceful protesters, many of whom remain in jail without trial or bail. Legitimate protest has long been a means of defusing pent-up discontent with government policies in India. The Centre has instead sought to criminalise it, branding dissent and disaffection as sedition to create a chilling effect. The CJP managed to overcome that ploy not only through the justness of its demands but also because the protesters’ identities as youth and students transcended the limited categories of religion, caste and even class (“richer farmers”) that the BJP sought to use to sow discord and delegitimise them. Even if it is too much to expect the Centre to seek similar relief for those held in earlier cases, the Court would do well to apply to them the standard it has now set for the CJP. Until it does, the relief granted to the CJP and its sympathisers will remain an exception rather than a principle.

Forging consensus

India must broaden engagement with regional multilateral groups

Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s attendance at the annual meeting of Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) leaders in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, marking 25 years of the Eurasian grouping, had a multi-pronged agenda. This was an occasion to meet his counterparts, for the first time since the U.S.-Israel war on Iran began more than six months ago, which has inflicted economic costs on the whole grouping. The grouping includes Iran, as well as Pakistan that has emerged a mediator between Iran and the U.S., and the Bishkek declaration that condemned the U.S. and Israel’s attacks on Iran and supported Iran’s right to peaceful nuclear technology under the NPT, was significant. Many of the SCO members are also in the BRICS grouping who Mr. Modi will host in Delhi on September 12-13 – this includes Russian President Vladimir Putin, Chinese President Xi Jinping and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian. New Delhi is keen to forge consensus on a joint declaration, which has been difficult due to UAE-Iran tensions and Mr. Modi’s discussions with Mr. Pezeshkian included BRICS cooperation. India’s ties with the Central Asian Republics have flagged due to other pre-occupations, making Mr. Modi’s visits to Tashkent and Bishkek, and meetings with regional leaders this time, an important initiative to revive talks on trade, critical minerals, tourism and other areas. As Pakistan takes over the SCO chairmanship, the Bishkek Summit allowed Mr. Modi to set out India’s agenda for the coming year. His speech at the Summit focused on the importance of dismantling the ecosystem of “terrorist financing, recruitment, radicalisation, and safe havens”, calling on the SCO to eschew “double standards” on terrorism. He also pressed for a strong message to countries that “use terrorism as an instrument of policy and provide safe haven and support to terrorists” – a pointed reference to India’s oft-repeated concerns about Pakistan. The Bishkek declaration’s inclusion of strong language on “all forms” of terrorism, including cross-border, has thus been welcomed by New Delhi. It remains to be seen how far the Pakistan presidency will take these ideas forward.

Compared to the high-octane optics and the Modi-Putin-Xi handshake at the 2025 Tianjin SCO Summit, this year’s summit was relatively sombre. The U.S.’s tariffs, its war with Iran and sanctions on Russia have damaged economic security, energy security and connectivity (the Hormuz Strait blockade), and pose major challenges to the grouping. For India, after tensions with Pakistan had peaked last year after the Pahalgam attacks and the four-day conflict, the past year has been sobering, given Pakistan’s diplomatic forays with the U.S., and the new security pact with Saudi Arabia and Türkiye. In the altered geopolitical framing, India must seek to broaden its engagement with all regional multilateral organisations such as the SCO.

It is the season of youth in India, without any formal commemorative event to mark it. They are being courted like never before. Political parties across the aisle, Ministries, Departments, think tanks and media organisations of every kind are engaging with the theme of youth. Education and examination systems are being reassessed; skills and coaching processes are under scrutiny; unemployment is being scanned and nuanced.

The whole nation seems occupied with the subject. Political parties are ramping up their conversations on digital platforms, where young people are assumed to reside. Leaders are recasting their hitherto successful models of communication to capture the attention and gain the confidence of Generation Z – the 14-to-29-year-olds – while mimicking their candid vocabulary. College and school campuses are crowded by political personalities. The overstretch almost suggests a desperation to connect.

There have been youth initiatives

Not that the youth have never been cared for. Governments, past and present, have taken up initiatives for youth development. The last 12 years have witnessed a plethora of schemes directed at them, covering employment, entrepreneurship, skill enhancement, education, internships, sports and volunteering. The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, while facing flak in certain respects, has managed to focus on quality learning geared towards innovation and the empowerment of young citizens. The proposed National Youth Policy 2026 seeks to prepare those in the 15-29 age group for the new digital age.

But beyond the good schemes, there is a lag in understanding Gen Z and Gen A (those born after 2010), who have begun to demand accountability. A NITI Aayog report speaks of 8.7 crore people in the 15-29 age group who are ‘not in education, employment or training’ (NEET). Despite clarifications from the government that NEET does not necessarily mean joblessness, a staggering amount of youthful energy still awaits an anchor. The yawning gap between formal degrees and job prospects remains a daunting problem. In the wake of the recent street protests, the Opposition has built a narrative that the ruling dispensation is hostile to younger generations. The question is: do they have a blueprint for the country’s youth, or are they only making political capital out of the current ferment?



Akshay Rout

Former Director General, Election Commission of India, and a public policy commentator

India’s Gen Z is gaining political attention, but is yet to consolidate into a viable electoral bloc

Not taking away from the goodwill of political entities towards the nation’s future generations, the overwhelming context is the chorus orchestrated by the country’s youth in Delhi and other places in recent weeks. While the youth furore and its consequences in India bear no comparison with the cataclysmic happenings in parts of the South Asian neighbourhood, a wake-up call has been sounded to those in power and those seeking to get there. The response, however exaggerated, is welcome. Parties and leaders now appear to be grappling with issues concerning the youth, regardless of whether they are motivated by electoral politics.

More an elusive vote

India has the largest youth population in the world; 65% of its nearly 1.5 billion people are below 35 years of age. About 23% of the country’s electorate falls in the 18-29 age category. In elections in recent years, including the latest Assembly elections in Tamil Nadu, Assam, West Bengal, Kerala and Puducherry, there was no discernible trend of young people voting in any political direction. The outcome in Tamil Nadu showed some hints of youth consolidation, but it was far from being based on any alternative youth agenda. In last year’s Bihar election, noticeable efforts by political groups to advance a youth agenda did not generate much appeal. Certain studies, however, suggest that young voters partly influenced the verdicts in the 2014 and 2019 general elections.

In the 75-year electoral history of India, while votes have been garnered under labels such as community, caste, class, farmers, industrial workers and even government employees, there has been no block identification of the youth as yet. There are steady references to the votes of Dalits, minorities, Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and Other Backward Classes, as well as the Yadav vote in Uttar Pradesh and the so-called M-Y vote in Bihar – patterns that have held steady over decades.

To these has now been added, in good measure, the women’s vote. A house for shelter, a toilet on the premises, gas in the kitchen and electricity at home can capture the imagination of women across regions, besides cash delivered directly into their wallets. Gratitude is then expressed through the ballot.

For reasons yet to be overcome, caste and community continue to abide as assured aggregators in the electoral arena. These, along with gender identity, have considerably subsumed youth identity. Critical issues such as

For newborns, the answer is hospital plus home

In India, newborns are dying. Earlier, they used to die at home without medical care. Now, they are dying in hospitals. On August 24, 2026, three newborns lost their lives in an accidental fire at the government women’s hospital in Amravati, Maharashtra. This was not the first such episode in government newborn care units, and it will not be the last – unless we view it not as an isolated event, but as a trend.

These are episodes of clustered newborn deaths in the government institutions (that were identified by ChatGPT)/in the format of Year/Government hospital/Newborn deaths – 2017 BRD Medical College, Gorakhpur 17; 2017 Government hospital, Ahmedabad 18; 2019 JK Lon Hospital, Kota 10; 2020 JK Lon Hospital, Kota 9; 2020 Government hospital, Shahdol 8; 2021 District Hospital, Bhandara One fire 10; 2021 Kamla Nehru Children’s Hospital, Bhopal One fire 4; 2021 Government Medical College, Ambikapur 4; 2022 Medical College, Ambikapur 4; 2023 Government Medical College, Nanded 12; 2024 Maharani Laxmi Bai Medical College, Jhansi One fire 10; 2025 District Women’s Hospital, Budaun 4; 2026 District Women’s Hospital, Amravati One fire 3

This is not a comprehensive national registry, but only a partial list. The pattern, however, is recurring and therefore demands a systemic response.

The problems and challenges

What is going wrong? The first reason is overcrowding. India has achieved remarkable success in ensuring that women increasingly deliver in health institutions – from 39% in 2005-06 to 90% in 2023-24 (National Family Health Survey-6). But this success has created a new challenge. The absolute number of women delivering in institutions has risen from 109 lakh in 2005 to 194 lakh in 2024-25 (Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW), Government of India). The total number of sick newborns hospitalised in public Special Newborn Care Units (SNCUs) has also risen rapidly, from 11.3 lakh in 2021-22 to 14.45 lakh in 2023-24 – a 28% increase in two years (Health Management Information System, MoHFW). Hence, newborn-care units everywhere are becoming overloaded.



Abhay Bang

Physician and the founder of Society for Education, Action and Research in Community Health (SEARCH), a community health research organisation

Newborn care in India must combine safer, decongested neonatal units with strengthened home-based support

The second reason is the changing case mix. As institutional deliveries have expanded, government hospitals have become the destination not only for normal deliveries but also for large numbers of high-risk births, including premature, low-birth-weight and sick newborns referred from peripheral facilities.

Infrastructure failures are the third reason. The Gorakhpur episode of August 2017 was attributed by a district-level inquiry to oxygen deprivation following an interruption in oxygen supply. The fires at Bhandara in January 2021, Bhopal in November 2021 and Jhansi in November 2024, as well as the more recent incident in Amravati, demonstrate the risks posed by fire and electrical hazards in neonatal units. Sick newborns need warmers, incubators and ventilators. Overcrowding can increase the electrical load on these units.

Infection and staffing problems would be the fourth reason. Overcrowding, inadequate nurse-to-baby ratios, equipment shortages and poor infection-prevention practices can turn a neonatal unit into a setting where hospital-acquired infections can spread rapidly.

The Gadchiroli model

This diagnosis leads to some obvious solutions. But there is an additional way.

India already has another solution. More than two decades ago, the Gadchiroli field trial conducted by the Society for Education, Action and Research in Community Health (SEARCH) demonstrated that trained community health workers (CHWs) could provide effective home-based neonatal care (HBNC), resulting in a 62.2% reduction in neonatal mortality in the rural area (The Lancet, 1999). The trained CHWs identified and managed neonatal infections at home, supported breastfeeding and warmth, and managed low-birth-weight and preterm babies. Subsequent data from Gadchiroli, published in the Journal of Perinatology in 2005, showed that between 1996 and 2003, 97% of low-birth-weight and preterm babies – including those with birth weights above 1,800 g and gestational ages of more than 34 weeks – were managed at home, with a very low case-fatality rate.

The principles of the Gadchiroli model have

employment and education constitute only a loose overhang.

Youth participation in India’s elections has remained low-key compared with other demographic categories, despite an improvement in recent years, and largely due to the mobilisation efforts of the Election Commission of India (ECI). The ECI has recently galvanised its electoral literacy campaigns to orient students in schools and colleges to the electoral system, processes and practices, and to secure their informed participation.

The upcoming Assembly elections in Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Manipur and Goa will be the earliest test case to determine whether the noisy voice of the streets gets organised into a political preference, including the amount of youth candidature. A quarter of the Assembly seats in these States, especially in politically muscular Uttar Pradesh, were won roughly by margins of around 5% and could, hence, easily be swung by Gen Z voters. The comparison ends there. The youth of Uttar Pradesh and Punjab do not share a common predicament; neither do the Gen Z in Goa and Manipur, or, for that matter, the youth of Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh, which go to the polls later in 2027. Electorally speaking, the current political attention on the youth can be interpreted as an attempt to cut possible losses while making a moderate investment.

Old equations do matter

Political parties cannot abandon time-tested voting blocs for an undependable, heterogeneous multitude that may or may not walk out of its Instagram residency. Old social calculations and booth management may still hold good in actual polls, while the youth awakening may remain a story on the side. Political parties and poll campaigners have a professional finger on the pulse of the people; they will carefully watch the emergence of a real Gen Z vote from the cradle, while they adjust their plans and campaigns just that bit for now.

In the text of the Union government’s vision of a developed India by 2047, the youth are regarded as the *Amrit Peedhi* (the generation of the nectar). But in realpolitik, the forthcoming State elections may show which side the nectar sweetens or whether it does so at all. Swami Vivekananda spoke of the power of youth, but in an electoral sense, that power may only now be crystallising in India.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The first step

The alleged theft of devotees’ donations, amounting to hundreds of crores, has seriously eroded the credibility of the Ayodhya Ram Temple administration and the Yogi Adityanath government in Uttar Pradesh. The U.P. government apparently had no inkling of what was going on. The move to

appoint a retired Air Marshal as the CEO of the Ram Temple Trust (Inside pages, September 3) and other carefully selected trustees is a step towards injecting professionalism into the administration. It is incumbent upon the U.P. Government to keep a hawk’s eye on the temple administration and conduct periodic checks to ensure

that everything is functioning smoothly.
C.V. Aravind,
Bengaluru

Building castles in the air

One really wonders why the Congress party and the Tamilaga Vetttri Kazhagam (TVK) in Tamil Nadu are thinking aloud about who should be the next Prime Minister of India — Rahul

Gandhi, Congress leader and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, or C. Joseph Vijay, TVK president and Tamil

Nadu Chief Minister. Mr. Vijay has completed only 100-odd days as Chief Minister. Rather, he is still an

Corrections & Clarifications

A report, “Air Force veteran appointed first Ram Temple Trust CEO” (Inside pages, September 3, 2026), incorrectly referred to Air Marshal Jeetendra Mishra (retired) as *Air Vice-Marshall Jitendra Mishra* (retd.) in both the text and the caption of the photograph.

The Readers’ Editor’s office can be contacted by Telephone: +91-44-28576300; E-mail: readerseditor@thehindu.co.in

apprentice on the job and should focus on becoming a successful Chief Minister. Moreover, Prime Minister Narendra Modi is still on a strong wicket and, at this point in time, appears irreplaceable.

S. Ramakrishnasayee,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

THE HINDU

2935 Belgium recorded 2,935 excess deaths during successive heatwaves between June and August 2026, according to the Sciensano national public health institute. Of these, 2,035 extra deaths were recorded between June 18 and July 3, while another 535 occurred between July 4 and 17. **AFP**

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

IN THE LIMELIGHT



A filmmaking legend:Singeetham understands that not everything needs to be said through dialogue, a skill he has excelled in since his early days as a writer. FILE PHOTO

Inside the mind of Singeetham Srinivasa Rao: a masterclass in storytelling

Veteran filmmaker and an instinctive writer, Rao has spent several years exploring the possibilities of storytelling — across languages, genres and forms. At 95, he remains as curious about cinema as he has always been

Sudhish Kamath

Kamal Haasan once told me that every storyteller has one story and they just find different ways to say it. “One man in another man’s shoes,” he winked, talking about his oldest living collaborator Singeetham Srinivasa Rao.

Seemed like the perfect icebreaker for an interview with the 95-year-old legendary storyteller.

For a lot of his films begin by disturbing someone’s identity or place in the world – Shekhar and Ranga in *Sommokadidhi Sokokadidhi*, Kamal in *Pushpak*, Apoorva *Sagodharargal* and Michael *Madana Kama Rajan*. Does putting a character in a situation where they don’t belong, inspire the story, I ask the legend over a Zoom call on a Wednesday morning.

The starting point

“Yes, though there are a lot of these common elements, the starting point is always an idea. Let me give you some examples: *Sing Geetham* was an idea that I got many years ago from a conversation with Balamurali Krishna when he said there’s music in everyday life. And I wanted to explore how to capture that music from life.”

He demonstrates with an example from *Sing Geetham* where a random line spoken blends two notes. *Pushpak*, he says, was born out of a desire to pay tribute to the era of silent films and Chaplin.

And *Aditya 369* was a film that was inspired not just by H.G. Wells and the *Back to the Future* films but by Mark Twain’s *A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur’s Court*.

Twain’s book, one of his early influences, might offer a clue on where Rao got hooked to the concept of one man in another man’s world.

Entering the cave

There were simply no screenwriting books or textbooks when he started filmmaking. One of the first lessons his mentor K.V. Reddy gave him was that every detail on paper is sacred.

“If you write cave, the production and camera departments will not know automatically that it has to be dark. You have to write dark cave.” And that’s how Rao learnt on set, as young writers figure out, the significance of the scene header INT./EXT. LOCATION - DAY/NIGHT.

Rao is a writer with instinct – when he starts to write a story, he never tries to guess if it is working or not. “You have to go with your conviction. Nobody will know whether it’s working or not until people watch it and tell you,” he laughs. So, it is a bit of shooting in the dark, sticking to the conviction, which is why it helps that he is always thinking of the little details to flesh out the scene.

Music and spark in the detail

I prod him on *Pushpak* – the way the audio of the Finance Minister’s speech on radio on the need to respect retired officers, is in sharp contrast to the behaviour of an old man checking out a maid, or even that scene with scatological humour without resorting to the sounds of toilet humour. “Yes, contrast is always the best way to find comedy in the scene. What if the place where he got the drunk man tied up is next door to a dance school?” And that’s how the sound of the classical dance instructor in the background provides the score for a scene that could have potentially grossed out audiences. And with the contrast, they laugh with him instead.

As an instinctive writer, Rao understands that not everything needs to be said through dialogue, a skill he has excelled in since his early days as a writer, from *Sommokadidhi Sokokadidhi*, where we get a peek into conman Ranga’s mind

when he watches Shekhar at work. There are a lot of Chaplinesque silent movie devices he employs in it that he carried forward to *Pushpak*, where one suspects his love for finding the music in life led him to think of two ideas – the silent film and the musical film where everyone sings out their lines.

It took decades before he could get from the first to the second, but he continued using musical narration to achieve great economy in storytelling.

You might remember the narrator singing the fable of *Michael Madana Kama Rajan*. By the time the opening credits end, we know how they were separated at birth.

Resolving conflict through laughs

How does Rao negotiate writer-star conflicts during the writing process, I wonder, especially since he has collaborated most with Kamal Haasan, who is often credited on screenplays of his films. “There’s no negotiation. Only collaboration. Because without a star, there’s no film,” he laughs.

How did he learn the art of comedy? Larry David, for example, found his voice by subverting social interactions. Garry Shandling struggled with self-doubt and decided that if he is funny in real life, he doesn’t have to learn to be funny on stage.

Rao says he does not know about any of that theory. “I think I have always had a sense of humour. That’s probably the secret of my health. I am hale and hearty because I laugh a lot.”

He narrates a story from many decades ago, when he and his friend Ananthu had to travel by train from Madras to Bombay, pretending to be siblings to match with the identities on the ticket. So, they wore dark glasses, pretending to have conjunctivitis. “But throughout the journey, I could not stop laughing. I could not keep a straight face.”

That anecdote does offer an insight into how Rao discovered the comedy of the average Joe in an otherworldly situation.

Finally, I ask him for a writing exercise that might help young filmmakers discover their own voice. “Take any proverb you like. Any old saying. And turn it into a modern story,” he suggests.

Traditional wisdom and universal truths explored through an everyday lens might just help a young writer or two discover who they are as writers.

Also, Rao has never stopped watching films. From the days he and Balu Mahendra went film-hopping at international film festivals, to discussing *Pather Panchali* with Satyajit Ray and deconstructing Manmohan Desai’s lost-and-found tropes.

“In one scene, three guys are giving blood to each other. People just didn’t care that it’s not realistic,” he recalls of that iconic scene from *Amar Akbar Anthony*.

Even recently, he reached out to this writer after watching his film *Culture Vulture* on YouTube and sought to reach out to Ravish Kumar to share his words of appreciation for ‘While You Were Watching’.

It was a year ago when this writer had approached Rao for an interview on his writing process. Between then and now Rao has already had a highly acclaimed release in *Sing Geetham*, serves as a story consultant on *Kalki 2898 AD* and is sharp enough to get working on the next – a historical spy thriller currently in the early stages of writing – yet another twist to one man’s adventure in another man’s world?

At 95, the incredible true story of a young man who couldn’t stop laughing, finding himself in many adventures with Kamal Haasan, is far from over. He is still finding new worlds to put his men into – and new ways to make us laugh.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of “bolt from the blue”? (R. Ranjith Kumar, Eraiyur)

This is an expression, which has been a part of the English language for a very long time. When you say that something was a “bolt from the blue” or a “bolt out of the blue”, it means that it was sudden and totally unexpected; whatever happened really surprised you. Here are a few examples.

The news that Sumithra had lung cancer was a bolt from the blue.

Gauri seemed to really like her new job. So when she informed her parents last week that she was planning on quitting, it was a bolt out of the blue.

The word “blue” in the expression refers to the blue sky and “bolt” refers to thunderbolts. On a day when the sky is blue and there are no clouds around, one does not expect to hear thunder. If one does, one is really surprised.

What is the meaning of the term “vox populi”? (G. K. Karthigakumaran, Chennai)

This is an expression borrowed from Latin meaning “voice of the people”. The term is often abbreviated to either “vox pop” or “vox pops”.

The vox pop technique is normally used in radio and television broadcasting. We often see reporters walking around on the streets asking passers by to give their opinion about something. For example, we have people responding to questions as to whether America did the right thing by bombing Afghanistan.

This method of recording the opinions of people talking informally in public places is called vox populi or vox pop.

Sai Prasad is a director who likes to make use of vox pop in his programmes.

Can you get me some vox populi by six this evening?

What is the difference between “plenty” and “aplenty”? (S.S. Prasanna Venkatesh, Chennai)

As far as the meaning is concerned there is hardly any difference between the two. Both mean “large amounts of”. Of the two “aplenty” is considered old fashioned. Here are a few examples.

Plenty of children joined the competition.

We have plenty of sugar left. When you use the word “aplenty”, it usually comes after the noun. For example,

Children aplenty joined the competition.

We have sugar aplenty. I have read thrillers aplenty.

It would be wrong to say “aplenty children”, “aplenty thrillers”, etc.

How does one refer to one’s country? “fatherland” or “motherland”? (T. Desai, Mumbai)

How you refer to your country depends upon what your mother tongue happens to be. In most Indian languages, we generally use the feminine gender to refer to our country. Native speakers of English invariably refer to their country as their “motherland”. But the Germans, on the other hand, refer to Germany as their “fatherland”. So, both “motherland” and “fatherland” are acceptable ways of referring to one’s country. Published in *The Hindu* on November 13, 2001

THE DAILY QUIZ

Gloria Steinem passed away yesterday at the age of 92. Here is a quiz on the eminent American feminist and journalist

Radhika Santhanam

QUESTION 1
What was the name of the feminist magazine she co-founded in 1971 which survives till today?

QUESTION 2
Steinem said once that she had never wanted children because she already had one. Who was she referring to?

QUESTION 3
Steinem was part of the second wave of feminism. Name the book credited with launching this wave, written by Betty Friedan.

QUESTION 4
In 2005, Steinem, Robin Morgan, and X co-founded an organisation that “works to make women visible and powerful in the media”. Name X, an actor who starred in *Klute* and *Coming Home*.

QUESTION 5
In a controversial op-ed, Steinem once defended a U.S. President saying his behaviour with women may have been reckless, but did not meet the legal definition of sexual harassment or assault. Which President was she talking about?



Visual question: Where did she work, which led to her seminal 1963 undercover exposé, ‘A Bunny’s Tale’?

Questions and answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. The year and place where Lionel Messi won the Olympic Gold and the Under-20 World Cup. **Ans: 2008 at Beijing and 2005 in the Netherlands**
2. Goals and assists by Messi in his 207-match career for ‘La Albiceleste’ **Ans: 125 goals, with 111 with his left foot, and 68 assists**
3. Messi had a senior international debut to forget on August 17, 2005, because he was shown a straight red card, less than a minute after coming on in the 63rd minute, for an accidental elbow to an opponent, against this European team. **Ans: Hungary**
4. The final heartbreak which prompted Messi’s first international retirement in June 2016. **Ans: The Copa America defeat to Chile**
5. Messi holds the record for most major tournament goals in men’s history with ____ goals. **Ans: 35**
6. Messi share the record for FIFA World Cup appearances (six in total) with this football player. **Ans: Cristiano Ronaldo**
7. He has netted the most international goals (11) against this South American country. **Ans: Bolivia**
Visual: Messi is celebrating the triumph in this tournament. **Ans: The Finalissima against Italy in 2022**
Early birds: Arun Kumar Singh | Sudhir Thapa | Tito Shiladitya | Piyali Tuli | Samir Gupta



Please send in your answers to
dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Word of the day

Boulevard:
a wide street or thoroughfare

Synonyms: avenue

Usage: *The hotel overlooks a tree-lined boulevard.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/boulevard

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ˈbuː.ləˌvɑːd/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

No defence ties with Pak., Belgium assures India

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

A photograph showing two men shaking hands. On the left is Shri Manoj Kumar Singh, the Indian Defence Minister, wearing a white kurta and a striped vest. On the right is a man in a dark blue suit and pink tie, representing the British side. They are standing in front of a backdrop that reads 'रक्षा मंत्रियों के द्विपक्षीय वाता' (Bilateral Meeting of Defence Ministers) and 'Defence Minister Bilateral Meeting'. A calendar icon shows the date as 03. The location 'Delhi' is also visible on the backdrop.

“Whether it is Ukraine or West Asia, we support all efforts aimed at an early end to conflicts and the restoration of peace. And

Paid tributes

The two leaders also paid tributes to the more than 9,000 Indian soldiers who perished in the Flanders

The Belgian dignitary expressed support to In-

Congress questions GDP revision, asks government to explain methodology

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday said the *shuddhikara* (purification) of the Ramlika ground in Haldwani area of Uttarakhand, where he had addressed a political rally, amounted to practising "untouchability", and said his party would approach Rajya Sabha Chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan over the issue.

urging him to direct Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami to ensure that an FIR was registered against those responsible for the alleged purification ritual.

FIR has been filed against the organisations and individuals involved in this heinous act," he said.

sis," he said in his letter.

The Congress president said the ritual was contrary to the spirit of the Constitution and human values.

Mr. Kharge also questioned the silence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah on the issue..

He also defended the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, who had criticised the purification ritual. An FIR was subsequently registered against Mr. Gandhi over his remarks.

Congress leader K.C. Venugopal said Mr. Gandhi will not be intimidated by cases against him.

economy," he asked.

The questions came days after the government highlighted 7.8% real GDP growth in the April-June 2026 quarter. Mr. Ramesh said the figure required closer scrutiny and alleged that the revisions had made the growth rate appear stronger than it was.

Mr. Ramesh said nominal growth in the latest quarter would have been closer to 2.6%, instead of the reported 10.3%, had the earlier base not been revised downwards. He cited concerns raised by former Chief Economic Adviser Arvind Subramanian and the IMF over India's national accounts, arguing that the Centre needed to provide greater transparency on the methodology underlying the estimates.

Congress leader K.C. Venugopal said Mr Modi was “a creator of a manipulated world”. “Let him live in that world but the reality is quite different,” he said.

Garg's analysis

He pointed to repeated revisions to the GDP estimate for April-June 2025, which had brought the figure down from about ₹86 lakh crore to ₹80 lakh crore.

Citing calculations by former Finance Secretary Subhash Chandra Garg,

Cong. leaders discuss issues in Punjab unit

word on the details of the meeting on Punjab, but it comes ahead of a proposed political yatra by Mr. Gandhi in the State, where elections are scheduled to be held early next year.

The dates for the yatra are likely to be finalised once the Congress resolves the intense factionalism in the Punjab unit.

Upset at not being made the PCC chief or the Chief Ministerial face before the Punjab polls, former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi and his supporters had expressed displeasure that the Scheduled Castes do not get adequate representation. The party is likely to urge him to spearhead the poll campaign in the State, sources indicated.

The top leadership of the Congress, including the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and party general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal, is said to have discussed the leadership tussle within the party in Punjab at a meeting at party president Mallikarjun Kharge's official residence.

In a separate meeting, the top leaders also met Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu and the Pradesh Congress Committee chief to discuss a possible Cabinet reshuffle in the State. There was no official

the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

At a press briefing, BJP MP Sudhanshu Trivedi said Mr. Alvi's statement reflected the Congress's attitude of "insulting the Indian Army and the Shri Ram Temple" and described it as evidence of the "*dimagi* Naxal" mindset.

Targeting the Congress, he said its leaders demanded proof of the surgical strike, the Balakot strike, and called India's Army chief a "*sadakhchhap gunda*" (street thug). "These are the same people whose leader Navjot Singh Sidhu went and hugged Pakistan's Army chief Qamar Bajwa," he said.

Even after the statements by Pakistan's Prime Minister and President about 'Operation Sindoor', if the Congress still had doubts, anyone harbouring such doubts could only be a "*dimagi* Naxal", he alleged.



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 - Opening date : 16.00 Hours of dt.22.09.2026.

Tender details can be seen from the e-procurement portal: www.tendersorissa.gov.in, Corrigendum or Addendum if any will not be published in newspapers and can be seen in e-procurement portal as well as in IDCO website.

Chief General Manager (Civil), IDCO, Bhubaneswar

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Raj.Samwad/C/26/10524 (Additional Director)

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT CIRCLE DIDWANA

दिनांक :- 26.08.2026

क्रमांक :- अ.प्र.अ.प. / बी / 2026-27 / 1310

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Short Term Notice Inviting Bid No 07/2026-27

01 Bids for Road works are invited from interested bidder upto 06:00 PM on Tuesday, 26 September 2026 . Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajabhutan.gov.in/http://spnp.rajb.nic.in>) of the State. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 287.31 Lacs.

Superintending Engineer
PWD Circle Didwana

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INBRIEF



NRI deposits lift rupee to a two-month high of ₹94.6

The Indian rupee appreciated to a two-month high of ₹94.60 against the dollar on September 3, a day after the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) mopped up \$137 billion through FCNR(B) deposits, external commercial borrowings and overseas foreign currency borrowings. The domestic currency opened at ₹94.30, down 50 paise from the previous close of ₹94.70 against the dollar. The rupee then gradually weakened to settle at the day's closing level.

Aditya Birla Group forays into wires and cables business

Aditya Birla Group announced its entry into the wires and cables business under brand Ultravolt. This marks the group's fourth new business foray in three years which includes paints, jewellery and a B2B e-commerce platform Birla Pivot. With an investment of ₹1,800 crore, Ultravolt will be the second largest player in the wires segment by capacity, the company said. Housed under UltraTech Cement Ltd., the business aims to be one of the top two players within five years.

PayPal says 220 employees hit in latest India restructuring

PayPal said approximately 220 employees in India were affected by workforce reductions on August 31 – representing about 4% of its India employee headcount – disputing reports of substantially higher job cuts in the country. The digital payments company said the reduction was part of its previously announced multi-year transformation programme aimed at simplifying global operations, strengthening execution, and positioning the company for long-term growth.

FLY91 inks firm order for 40 ATR aircraft



Flying higher: Fly91 will will lease another six to eight aircraft before the new aircraft begin arriving.

The Hindu Bureau

NEW DELHI

Regional airline FLY91 signed a firm order for 40 70-seater ATR 72-600 aircraft, marking the largest ATR order globally by any regional airline. The deal is valued at about \$1 billion though clients negotiate discounts on listed price. The airline will lease another six to eight aircraft before the new aircraft begin arriving. For the Fran-

co-Italian aircraft maker, a big Indian order comes nine years after IndiGo ordered 50 ATRs in 2017. The airline, unveiled in 2024, operates 280 weekly flights to 12 destinations. It connects Pune, Sindhudurg, Solapur and Jalgaon in Maharashtra; Agatti in Lakshadweep Islands; Hubballi in Karnataka; Tirupati, Vijayawada and Rajahmundry in AP; along with Bengaluru, Goa, Kochi and Hyderabad.

No excuses left for textiles sector, says Goyal on tariffs

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan

NEW DELHI

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal said India's textile industry can no longer blame external factors for its weak export performance, noting that most developed markets now impose tariffs on Indian textile imports that are at par with or lower than those levied on key competitors such as Bangladesh and Vietnam. Speaking at a workshop here, Mr. Goyal explained for years the Indian textiles industry could not compete with Bangladesh and Vietnam because of a com-



Piyush Goyal

bination of the advantage Bangladesh continued to receive as a least-developed country (LDC), and the terms Vietnam has negotiated in various trade deals with developed countries. Many developed

SC disposes of SEBI appeals against NSE in two cases

Apex court takes note of nearly ₹1,500 cr. settlement between the regulator and the exchange in co-location and dark fibre cases; resolution comes ahead of the exchange's stock market debut

The Hindu Bureau

NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday disposed of a batch of appeals filed by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) against the National Stock Exchange (NSE) in the co-location and dark fibre cases, following a settlement of nearly ₹1,500 crore between the market regulator and the exchange.

A Bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and K. Vinod Chandran was hearing SEBI's appeals against orders of the Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT) setting aside disgorgement directions issued by the regulator against the NSE in the two cases. The Bench dis-



The cases stem from allegations that certain brokers were given preferential access to NSE's trading systems via co-location. REUTERS

posed of the appeals after taking note of the settlement between the parties. In July, SEBI had accepted two settlement applications filed by the NSE for an aggregate amount of about ₹1,492 crore. Of this,

about ₹1,224 crore pertained to the co-location case, while ₹268 crore related to the dark fibre case, also known as the leased-line connectivity case. The cases stem from allegations that certain brok-

ers were given preferential access to the NSE's trading systems through its co-location facility, potentially allowing them to receive market data ahead of others. The allegations of unfair access first surfaced following a whistle-blower complaint in January 2015.

The settlement comes as the country's largest stock exchange prepares for its stock-market debut, nearly a decade after it first sought to list its shares, with its plans having faced prolonged regulatory hurdles.

The proposed initial public offering (IPO) is expected to raise around ₹30,000 crore, which would make it one of the largest IPOs in India's capital market history.

GJC calls for balancing economic patriotism with cultural heritage

The Hindu Bureau

NEW DELHI

While welcoming Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call for prioritising locally-made products and reducing gold imports, the All India Gem & Jewellery Domestic Council (GJC) has said that India must balance "economic patriotism" and cultural traditions

when it comes to gold jewellery. The council argued that the sector contributes "nearly 7-8%" to the economy and supports "millions of livelihoods". The GJC was reacting to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent and repeated appeal to all Indians to stop foreign trips and weddings, to buy local, and to only buy gold if necessary.

SEBI to make changes in CAS derivative price determination in a week

The Hindu Bureau

MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) is set to introduce changes to the methodology used to determine settlement prices for derivative contracts following the implementation of the newly introduced Closing Auction Session (CAS).

SEBI is expected to announce the changes in about a week.

The markets regulator said in a statement that it had engaged with market participants and other stakeholders after receiving feedback and suggestions on the CAS through multiple channels, including social media and other media platforms.

'Little investment in energy innovation'

Lalendu Mishra

PUNE

Indian Oil Corporation Ltd (IOCL) chairman A. S. Sahney lamented about the minuscule investment going into energy innovation. "For all our strength as an energy nation, we have to address a very uncomfortable fact that energy innovation in India got very less attention, very less capital than its importance demands," he told a gathering of start-up founders, academia and industry officials at CSIR-National Chemicals Laboratory (NCL) here. "In the last 5-6 years, barely 2% of India's overall startup funding has come to the energy sector. Of the total about ₹5.5 lakh crore that has gone into the startup ecosystem, only ₹11,000 cr. has gone to the

'In the last 5-6 years, barely 2% of India's overall startup funding has come to the energy sector'

energy sector. And that is a pity. That situation needs to be corrected very quickly," he said at an event held by MC² Foundation. "And if we take out areas like solar, wind, the funding comes down to less than ₹1,000 crore of the ₹5.5 lakh crore that have been spent," he added. He said innovation was crucial due to what was happening to the energy market as a whole. Stating India's energy demand will double in 15-20 years, he said "we need lots of innovations, lot of startups." (The writer was in Pune at the invitation of IOCL)

Filatex's new unit to recycle polyester textiles

The Hindu Bureau

COIMBATORE

Filatex India is investing about ₹300 crore to set up a polyester textile recycling plant in Gujarat with an annual capacity of 27,000 tonne, CMD Madhu Sudhan Bhageria said. The plant is expected to be commissioned next month and would recycle polyester textile waste into polyester chips. The company's in-house technology is capable of recovering around 80-85% of the polyester content from textile waste, the firm said.

Parliamentary panel flags 'punitive' tax regime, seeks data on new I-T Act's impact

Sobhana K. Nair

NEW DELHI

Members of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance, cutting across party lines, criticised the present Income Tax regime for relying excessively on what they described as "punitive action" and granting tax officials significant scope for overreach, at a meeting on Thursday.

The panel, headed by BJP MP Bhartruhari Mahatab, met to discuss "Direct Tax Reforms: Simplification, Rationalisation and Ease of Compliance" with representatives of the Department of Revenue in the Finance Ministry and the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT).

The committee also flagged compliance-related glitches in the implementation of the Income Tax Act, 2026, and sought additional information from the CBDT on its impact, including changes in tax revenue collections, the number of assesseees, and the volume of pending litigation.

GDP estimates

According to sources, at least one member raised the controversy surrounding the latest Gross Domestic Product (GDP) estimates, questioning the reliability of official growth figures in the context of former Union Finance Secretary Subhash Garg's claim that India's economy expanded by only 2.6% in



The committee flagged compliance-related glitches in implementation of the Act.

the June quarter rather than the officially reported 7.8%. "The issue was not on the agenda today, so it was not discussed further," a committee member said. Two themes dominated the discussions.

First, members expressed concern over the growing contribution of individual income taxpayers relative to corporate tax collections. Some pointed out that in several economies comparable to India, corporate tax collections significantly exceed those from individual taxpayers. Second, members criticised what they viewed as the Income Tax Department's heavy-handed approach to enforcement. "Why should all income taxpayers be treated as criminals? There is a spate of notices being issued, leaving taxpayers scrambling to prove that they have complied with all rules, while the rules themselves keep changing, sometimes even retrospectively," a ruling party member said.

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Published Tenders from 31-08-2026 to 02-09-2026
Stationery Department
Tender ID: 2026_STY_864241 2 * Stationery Controller * Supply of Multilayered Board 58 cm x 78 cm x 200 GSM * Closing Date: 14-Sep-2026 * PAC: Rs49997506
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S.V.GOSAMRAKSHANA SHALA e-TENDER NOTICE
NTT No. TTD/30/45/2025-SV Goshala, Dated: 02.09.2026
e-Tender is invited for "Manufacturing / Packaging / Supply of Agarabathi Products for TTD Agarabathi Unit" for a period of (03) three years as per T&C applies. Tender documents can be downloaded by login to https://tender.appeprocurement.gov.in, DOWNLOAD START DATE: 04-09-2026 from 04.00 PM and LAST DATE FOR SUBMISSION OF TENDER IS: 18-09-2026 up to 03.00 PM. For further details contact Mobile No: 9281413626.
TTD-40021(31)/1/2026-PRO SEC(Adv.No.173) Date:03-09-2026 EXECUTIVE OFFICER

WALK-IN INTERVIEW
(Under SC/ST Scheme)
Rajiv Gandhi Centre for Aquaculture (RGCA) a society under the Marine Products Export Development Authority (MPEDA) propose to conduct Walk-in interview on 18/09/2026 for engaging Lab Trainees.
For details, log on to www.rgca.co.in.
DIRECTOR, MPEDA - RGCA

MAHATRANSCO
Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.
INVITATION FOR BID (IFB) (LOCAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING)
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MSETCL invites offers by SRM e-tendering in TWO bid system (Techno-Commercial Bid and Price Bid) from the eligible registered bidders for the following work as detailed below.
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Interested bidders may obtain further information available on the website. https://srmetender.mahatransco.in
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Procurement of - Tender No. 1) KPCL/2025-26/ND2562/CALL-2 Lube oil cooler & spares. 2) KPCL/2025-26/ND2048/CALL-2 LT Cables. 3) KPCL/2026-27/ND2768 Liquid Sodium Hypochlorite. Last date for receipt of tender: For Sl. No. 1: 07.09.2026. For Sl. No. 2: 09.09.2026. For Sl. No. 3: 16.09.2026. Further details can be obtained from Executive Engineer (Purchase), Mobile: 094808 30377. E-mail: eepurchasets@gmail.com
4) KPCL/2026-27/PS/WORK_INDENT4644/CALL-2 Dated: 01.09.2026 Maintenance and Assistance to Operation of Pumps for Dust Suppression System of Coal Handling Plant Unit 1 & 2 for a period of one year. Total Tender Amount (Exclusive of GST): Rs.40,42,489/- EMD: Rs.80,900/- Last date for submission of bids: 09.09.2026 up to 17.00 Hrs. Further details can be obtained from Executive Engineer (CHP) Mechanical-1, Mobile: +91 94482 90756.
5) KPCL/2026-27/PS/WORK_INDENT4750 Date: 01.09.2026 Conducting Mandatory Energy Audit of (Unit-1 and 2, 500MW each) and (Unit-3, 700MW) of BTPS for the year 2026-27, as per the guideline of BEE, under energy conservation act 2001. Last date for receipt of tenders: 16.09.2026. Further details can be obtained from Executive Engineer (EPT), BTPS, KPCL, Kudithini-583 142, Karnataka. Mobile: 94808 30346. E-mail: eeepbtps@gmail.com
RAICHUR THERMAL POWER STATION
6) KPCL/2026-27/PS/WORK_INDENT4737 Date: 01.09.2026 Periodical Special Assistance and Annual Maintenance works of Generator transformers, Station transformers, ICTS, Line and Bus reactors, Unit Auxiliary transformers, Colony Power Supply Transformers & OLA transformers and allied equipments for a period of 12 months. EMD: Rs.1,15,245/- Last date for submission of bids (Both cover 1 & 2): 09.09.2026 up to 16.30 Hrs. Further details can be obtained from Executive Engineer (Transformer), RTPS, KPCL, Shaktinagar-584170, Raichur Dist. Mobile: 94495 96519.

MAXIMUM IMPACT

Smriti overtakes Harmanpreet to become India's highest six-hitter



Smriti Mandhana smashed seven maximums in the Asia Cup match against Hong Kong in Dubai to become India's highest six-hitter in T20Is with 95 from 173 matches (167 innings). She went past captain Harmanpreet Kaur's record of 89 (204 matches, 183 innings). The duo is followed by Shafali Verma (87 in 113 matches).

EYEING AN ENCORE

Laxman appointed India coach for the upcoming Asian Games



V.V.S. Laxman will be the coach of the Indian men's team at the Asian Games to be held in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, later this month. Laxman will be assisted by Sunil Joshi, Hrishikesh Kanitkar and Subhadeep Ghosh. Laxman had guided the team to the gold medal at the 2023 Asian Games in Hangzhou.

HANDLING WITH CARE

'The plan is to ensure the players get adequate rest in the future'



BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia said that the Board's FTP (Future Tours Programme) officials had been instructed to ensure the matches are scheduled in such a way to ensure adequate rest for the players. "We are hoping for acclimatisation and friendly matches before any major series in SENA countries," said Saikia.

BIG BOOST

Rahul, Siraj and Padikkal added to South Zone squad for final



India Test players K.L. Rahul, Mohammed Siraj and Devdutt Padikkal have been added to the South Zone squad for the Duleep Trophy final against East Zone. Left-arm pacer C.V. Milind has been included as a cover for Karnataka pacer Vidwath Kaverappa. The title decider will be played from September 6 to 10 in Chennai.



The powers that be: BCCI secretary Saikia and president Manhas arrive for the meeting. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Agarkar's absence raises eyebrows

BCCI MEETING

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

Ajit Agarkar's absence from the BCCI performance review meeting on Thursday has intensified speculation over his future as chief selector beyond this month.

Agarkar, who has chaired the National selection committee since July 2023, was the only key stakeholder missing from the high-profile meet.

BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia sought to downplay his absence, insisting that Agarkar was unavailable because of "personal commitments" and that the meeting had been organised "at short notice".

Yet, with Agarkar's existing contract set to expire, his non-attendance has fuelled murmurs about a growing distance between him and the Board's hierarchy. *The Hindu* understands that the relation-

ship between the two sides has been strained since July, when Saikia publicly issued a statement backing Rohit Sharma's continuation in India's ODI set-up without consulting Agarkar and his fellow selectors. The move created unease within the selection panel.

Since then, there has reportedly been no formal communication between the BCCI administration and Agarkar regarding a possible extension. Under the Board's regulations, the former India pacer is eligible for a contract renewal, which would allow continuity through the ODI World Cup cycle.

"There was no such discussion in the meeting," Saikia said when asked whether Agarkar would get another year at the helm. "Our focus was on the performance in England and Ireland as well as the Test series in Sri Lanka and what we are going to do in the upcoming series and the World Cup".

Smriti scales the summit as India enters semifinals

The left-hander surpasses Mithali to become the highest run-getter in women's internationals; she also goes past Lanning and Wolvaardt for most hundreds in the big win over Hong Kong

ASIA CUP
Press Trust of India
DUBAI

Smriti Mandhana slayed a host of records in her 64-ball 124 (14x4, 7x6) as India marched into the women's Asia Cup semifinals with a thumping 137-run win over Hong Kong here on Thursday.

India raced to 193 for five following a second T20I hundred from Smriti, who also surpassed Mithali Raj (10,868) to become the leading run-getter in women's internationals. Smriti has 10,880 to her credit.

She also went past Australian great Meg Lanning and current South African skipper Laura Wolvaardt for most hundreds (18) across formats.

The gulf between India and Hong Kong, playing its first Asia Cup since 2012, was clearly visible as the latter struggled to 16 for one in the PowerPlay, effectively putting the stiff target out of its reach. Hong Kong was bowled out for 56 in 16.2 overs.

India pacer Nandani Sharma swung the ball both ways and got rid of opener Mariko Hill with a beauty. None of the batters was able to take on the In-

dian attack. It was India's second win in as many games and the overwhelming favourite will take on Pakistan in its final group game on Saturday.

Earlier, Smriti made up for a sedate start rather quickly and shared a 74-run stand with her opening partner Shafali Verma (28, 17b, 3x4, 2x6) to set the tone for the innings.

The Hong Kong bowlers made life easier for the batters by offering too many loose deliveries.

Smriti became the first Indian woman to notch up two T20I hundreds when she brought up the milestone in the 17th over.

In the following over, she plundered a couple of sixes down the ground to go past Mithali in the leading run-scorers' chart.

"I didn't know all of this happened," said Smriti when informed about her record-breaking effort.

"It's really hard for me to play the slower bowlers. Having said that, I just love batting, and I'm happy that I could contribute."

The scores: India 193/5 in 20 overs (Smriti 124, Marina 2/46) bt Hong Kong 56 in 16.2 overs (Nandani 2/6, Shree Charani 2/16, Deepti 3/9, Prema 2/12). **Toss:** Hong Kong; **PoM:** Smriti. **India's next match: Sept. 5** vs. Pakistan, Dubai, 8 p.m. IST.



Blazing away: Smriti smashed 14 fours and seven sixes in her 64-ball 124. X@BCCIWOMEN

Silken touch and a stunning range

P.K. Ajith Kumar

On that warm afternoon in Jaipur, Smriti Mandhana was talking about her childhood, about how her mother instilled a sense of competitiveness in her.

"She always used to ask me to persevere, in whatever I did, and not to leave in the middle but to go on till reaching the top," Smriti told *The Hindu*. She also said she wanted to be the best batter in the world. She already was. And that was seven years ago.

Former New Zealand all-rounder Scott Styris even said, around that time, the difference between Smriti and the next batter in women's cricket was the size of Mumbai.

When one asked her if she was aware of that remark by Styris, she said she wasn't, but she was happy, and smiled. The smile that cricket fans

across the world have become so used to.

Sweet certainly that smile is, but her batting is sweeter. Not many cricketers, male or female, have made batting such a fine art. She is a treat to watch. Like David Gower or Sourav Ganguly was.

Runs continue to flow from her bat. As do records. There were more of them on Thursday.

During the Asia Cup match against Hong Kong in Dubai, she went past Mithali Raj, the woman who almost single-handedly put Indian women's cricket in the headlines when the sport had no takers, to become the leading scorer of international runs. She overtook Mithali's tally 10,868 runs during her innings of 124.

Smriti is only 30. She should be around for many more years. She will remain driven to be the best.

Numero uno

Smriti climbed to the top of the run charts in women's internationals, overtaking Mithali

SMRITI MANDHANA - 10880 runs						
Format	M	Inns	Runs	HS	Avg.	100s/50s
Tests	9	16	788	149	52.53	2/5
ODIs	120	120	5,411	136	47.88	14/35
T20Is	173	167	4,681	124	30.80	2/35
MITHALI RAJ - 10868 runs						
Tests	12	19	699	214	43.69	1/4
ODIs	232	211	7,805	125*	50.68	7/64
T20Is	89	84	2,364	97*	37.52	0/17
SUZIE BATES - 10740 runs						
Tests	-	-	-	-	-	-
ODIs	184	174	5,982	168	37.86	13/37
T20Is	186	178	4,758	124*	28.84	1/28

BCCI leaves Rohit's future up in the air

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

The Board of Control for Cricket in India's (BCCI) performance review meeting on Thursday did little to clear the air around Rohit Sharma's ODI future, with its public position, on the former captain's availability for selection, akin to a batsman deftly leaving a tricky delivery outside the off stump.

BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia, while addressing the media after the meeting, appeared to brush aside speculation over Rohit's future, pointing to the opener's recent form.

"He is playing superbly in all matches. What more do you want? He scored 138 in the last match (on July 19). Don't give fodder to such rumours," Saikia said.

The remarks came after a meeting of the key stakeholders of India's men's teams to review the performances in England and Ireland and chart a roadmap towards the 2027 ODI World Cup. Saikia, however, stressed that the gathering was not a selection meeting.

"Today we did not have any selection meeting, we had a routine meeting like



Perfect riposte: BCCI secretary Saikia brushed aside speculation over Rohit's future, pointing to the opener's century in the third ODI against England at Lord's. GETTY IMAGES

we have frequent meetings after an interval of two-three months.

"We discussed how our team performed in England and Ireland and a roadmap has been prepared so that we have a very good performance in the 2027 World Cup," he said.

Head coach Gautam Gambhir, Test and ODI captain Shubman Gill, T20I captain Shreyas Iyer,

Centre of Excellence head of cricket V.V.S. Laxman, BCCI president Mithun Manhas and Saikia attended the meeting. Chief selector Ajit Agarkar was absent owing to personal commitments.

Yet Rohit's name inevitably hovered over the proceedings.

In July, reports had suggested that the Lord's ODI against England on July 19 could be Rohit's last in In-

dia colours. Saikia had then firmly rejected the speculation.

"Rohit is a regular member of the Indian ODI team, and he will continue to represent the country as long as he is in the scheme of things. In other words, the Lord's ODI won't be his last match," Saikia had said on July 17.

The Hindu understands, however, that the selection committee, in consultation with the team management, had informed Rohit during the Chennai ODI against Afghanistan in June that he was not part of its plans beyond the England series. Rohit is understood to have reluctantly accepted the decision.

The selection committee's position, however, was subsequently overruled by the BCCI's administrative behemoths, leading to Saikia's public clarification ahead of the Lord's game.

Thursday's meeting did not revisit that decision in a formal manner. With Agarkar absent and no selection meeting on the agenda, the question of whether Rohit remains part of India's ODI plans was deliberately left unresolved.

Alcaraz and Sabalenka advance to the third round with ease

US OPEN

Reuters
NEW YORK

Carlos Alcaraz took another solid step in his comeback from injury while fellow defending champion Aryna Sabalenka also advanced at the US Open on Wednesday, as organisers heaved a sigh of relief after clearing a backlog of rain-delayed matches.

Former winner Daniil Medvedev weathered an avian interruption to soar into the next round, with Wimbledon women's champion Linda Noskova, Naomi Osaka, Iga Swiatek, Jessica Pegula, Emma Navarro, Ben Shelton and Frances Tiafoe also progressing.

Superb shot-making

Alcaraz took centre stage in the evening session on Arthur Ashe Stadium, where the Spanish second seed dropped the opening set before blowing away Jaime Faria 4-6, 6-0, 6-3, 6-2 with superb shot-making to ease any lingering fears about his wrist injury.



Businesslike: Sabalenka taught latcenko a few lessons during her second-round victory. GETTY IMAGES

Sabalenka was even more impressive a short while earlier on the main showcourt, as the Belarusian crushed Russian qualifier Polina Latcenko 6-1, 6-1.

Medvedev, the 2021 champion, had his feathers ruffled in a 6-1, 6-3, 7-5 victory over wildcard Sebastian Gorznyi when two birds landed on the net.

Third-ranked Pegula needed just 56 minutes to dismantle 2020 Australian Open winner Sofia Kenin

6-3, 6-1, while Swiatek, the 2022 champion, had it easier with a 6-3, 6-2 victory over Nadia Podoroska. Eighth seed Shelton had a more difficult time, beating Poland's Hubert Hurkacz 6-3, 5-7, 7-6(3), 7-5 as he relied on the energy of the home crowd to power through.

Wimbledon champion Linda Noskova eased to a 6-4, 6-2 win over Lanlana Tararudee in her bid for a second straight Major.

TOP RESULTS

Men: Second round: 7-Medvedev bt Gorznyi (USA) 6-1, 6-3, 7-5; 26-Rinderknech (Fra) bt Munar (Esp) 7-6(4), 6-2, 7-5; 22-Vacherot (Mon) bt Majchrzak (Pol) 6-4, 4-6, 7-6(3), 6-2; 11-Tiafoe (USA) bt Sakamoto (Jpn) 6-3, 7-6(2), 7-5; Merida (Esp) bt 23-Rublev 6-7(3), 6-2, 6-4, 6-4; 27-Etcheverry (Arg) bt Fearnley (GBr) 6-3, 6-3, 3-6, 6-3; 8-Shelton (USA) bt Hurkacz (Pol) 6-3, 5-7, 7-6(3), 7-5; 18-Lehecka (Cze) bt Samuel (GBr) 6-4, 6-2, 6-4; Tsitsipas (Gre) bt Harris (RSA) 6-7(1), 6-3, 7-6 (4), 6-4; 15-Bublik (Kaz) bt Mannarino (Fra) 6-3, 6-1, 6-1; 20-Paul (USA) bt Prizmic (Cro) 6-2, 6-3, 5-7, 6-4; 2-Alcaraz (Esp) bt Faria (Por) 4-6, 6-0, 6-3, 6-2.

Women: Second round: 8-Swiatek (Pol) bt Podoroska (Arg) 6-3, 6-2; 23-Mertens (Bel) bt Timofeeva 6-2, 7-6(5); 13-Osaka (Jpn) bt Siniakova (Cze) 6-2, 5-7, 6-1; 1-Sabalenka bt latcenko 6-1, 6-1; 15-Shneider bt Pliskova (Cze) 6-1, 7-6(4); 11-Kostyuk (Ukr) bt Stephens (USA) 6-1, 7-5; 18-Alexandrova bt Birrell (Aus) 6-1, 2-6, 6-3; 6-Noskova (Cze) bt Tararudee (Tha) 6-4, 6-2; 19-Paolini (Ita) bt Stefanini (Ita) 6-4, 6-1; 16-Cirstea (Rou) bt Parry (Fra) 6-2, 7-5; 21-Kalinskaya (Rus) bt Wang (Chn) 7-5, 2-6, 6-3; 9-Svitolina (Ukr) bt Joint (Aus) 6-2, 6-7(6), 6-4; 7-Muchova (Cze) bt Boulter (GBr) 6-1, 6-0.

R. Kaushik

Intrigue has been a constant subtext to cricket in the subcontinent in general, and Pakistan in particular. Once volatile and unpredictable, Pakistani cricket has, in recent times, been predictably messy and controversial, the latest events in England doing little to edify its image even as it struggles to come to terms with the reality that the glory days of the past on the field are a distant memory.

The unprecedented move to banish seven players, among them two former captains, as well as the head coach and the bowling coach midway through a series has to rank among the most bizarre and knee-jerk reactions. For effect, it is perhaps overshadowed by the Pakistan Cricket Board threat to pull out of the Lord's Test of last week because the host broadcaster aired an interview with the sons of inarguably the greatest cricketer to come out of the country, Imran Khan.

Imran is a charismatic, talismanic personality who did more to raise the stock of the nation itself than anyone else. Having cut his teeth as a raw, unpolished, fiery pacer in Sussex where he was one half of a feared new-ball combine alongside South African Garth le Roux, he blossomed into a fabulous all-rounder who formed a famed quartet – alongside Ian Botham, Kapil Dev and Richard Hadlee – for much of the 1980s. With the passage of time and the inevitable onset of injuries, he dropped pace but didn't lose much by way of impact, while upping his game a notch or three as a batter as compensation.

Crowning glory

But more than as a player, Imran's legacy was cemented through his leadership abilities. His arresting presence was unmistakable on the field of play, and even when he was involved in a captaincy musical chair battle of other people's making with Javed Miandad, he was unmissable. While others congregated around the bowler to congratulate him on taking a wicket, Imran would walk regally, at his own pace, from mid-on or mid-off; as he neared the protagonist, the rest would respectfully make way for him to pat the gushing hero on the back. Imran wasn't given to grand gestures, but his wards knew that a word of praise from the skipper was worth all the riches in the world.

His crowning glory was leading Pakistan, against all odds and from the brink of elimination, to the 1992 World Cup title. The conquest of England at a raucous MCG was the ultimate vindication of his inspirational qualities and the great gift of getting his colleagues to perform above themselves, to understand and believe that nothing was beyond them. He didn't entirely endear himself to thousands of his countrymen – among them some of his own teammates – and women by focussing more on the cancer hospital he was to open in Lahore in his late mother's name instead of eulogising the historic triumph at the post-match festivities, but even his critics acknowledged that his heart was in the right place.

Imran's plunge into politics was going to be interesting, to say the least. Historically, elected Pakistani governments have operated under the iron fist of the army but Imran was his own man, so it was inevitable that there would be tension – and that's putting it mildly. His imprisonment, his deteriorating health and concerns over his well being drove Greg Chappell, the former Australian captain and one of Imran's contemporaries, to spark an initiative that involved several internationals, many of them skippers of their respective national sides including our very own Sunil Gavaskar, to make an

impassioned official plea to the Pakistani dispensation to ensure that Imran is treated with the



Among the players bundled on to the plane back home were former captains Salman and Rizwan. The former, who had led the team in the first Test in the absence of Babar, was dropped for the second game

respect he deserves and is looked after from a medical perspective.

It's against this backdrop that the host broadcaster of the England-Pakistan Test series aired an interview, conducted by former England captain Mike Atherton at the Long Room, with Imran's sons Sulaiman and Kasim Khan during the Lord's Test. The Pakistan Cricket Board contemplated a boycott of the match midway before saner counsel prevailed, but that seemed to have deserted them at the conclusion of a second heavy defeat in two matches, at the end of which came the dramatic decision to recall half the team as well as Sarfaraz Ahmed, the head coach, and Umar Gul, the fast-bowling coach.

Among the players bundled on to the plane back home were former captains Salman Ali Agha and Mohammad Rizwan. Indeed, Salman had led Pakistan in the first Test in Leeds in the absence of Babar Azam, out injured; England won by an innings and 103 runs at Headingley, and once Babar was declared fit for the Lord's showdown, Salman was dumped from the playing XI for the second Test. Like Salman, Rizwan has captained the national team previously but paid the price for a middling run of scores. Also asked to fly back home was Imam-ul-Haq, the bespectacled opening batter and the nephew of revered and adored former captain Inzamam. Imam did not bat in either innings at Lord's with a low-grade calf strain which itself is now being probed, all of which has contributed to a horrible mid-series fiasco that incoming head coach Mike Hesson and Ashley Noffke, Gul's replacement, have been burdened with.

Change the only constant

Pakistan have roped in, and parted ways with, numerous leading luminaries as head coach, including Mickey Arthur, former Australia paceman Jason Gillespie and Gary Kirsten, the ex-opener from South Africa who coached India to the 50-over World Cup crown in 2011 and is now the head coach of the Sri Lankan national team. Kiwi Hesson is the latest in a long line of big-ticket names to embrace one of the most demanding tasks in world cricket, and not necessarily because

The unprecedented move to banish seven players, among them two former captains, as well as the head coach and the bowling coach midway through a series has to rank among the most bizarre and knee-jerk reactions; PCB must realise that unless it sets its house in order, the road to redemption will be strewn with thorns and boulders



GETTY IMAGES

of the pressure of expectations alone. Being the coach of the Pakistan team is not a double-edged sword; however, the sword constantly hovers overhead, despite the fact that almost all coaches have been compelled to function with one hand tied behind their back.

Pakistan's recent cricketing journey has been anything but successful. Apart from making it to the final of the T20 World Cup in Melbourne in 2022 when they were bested by England, they haven't quite matched history and expectations with performances. Their Test displays have been even more disappointing – they haven't so much as threatened to make it to the final of the World Test Championship over the first three cycles and are currently at the bottom of the nine-team standings of this latest campaign, with just 16 points from eight matches. To say that their chances of finishing in the top-two this time too are more miniscule than finding snow in the desert will be a massive understatement.

Tough road ahead

It's against this backdrop that Hesson, and Babar must embark on a journey of redemption and salvation. Neither will be unaware that for reasons beyond their control, the national team has become a laughing stock. Defeats by an innings, and by 194 runs, in seamer-friendly conditions where neither the batters nor the bowlers, with the honourable exception of Mohammad Abbas – who took nine wickets in the Lord's hammering – have covered themselves with glory, are impossible to bounce back from in a short series. While the rest of the cricketing world is bemoaning the increasing takeover of two-Test faceoffs, Pakistan would have loved for a third Test to not be there, given the unenviable position in which they find themselves.

Babar himself has been at the receiving end of selectorial vicissitudes more than once and must now find a way to rally his embattled, beleaguered troops who will look over their shoulder with a greater sense of insecurity than ever before. To lose so many key personnel in one swoop and still be expected to mount a face-saving fightback is a humongously tall task but between them, the leadership group of Babar, the best batter in the side, and Hesson have no other option. In less than a week's time, Joe Root's England, who themselves have little chance of making it to the WTC final, will be licking their lips in anticipation of a 3-0 sweep.

Fearsome attack

There was a time when England dreaded the prospect of running into Pakistan, even at home, with the imperious Wasim Akram and the toe-crushing Waqar Younis primed to wreak untold damage. So mesmerised were they with the late reverse swing the two magicians procured in 1992 that they threw unsubstantiated allegations of ball-tampering until Geoff Boycott, the straight-talking

Yorkshireman, mocked those charges by saying that the duo was so skilled that it could 'bowl England out with an orange'. It's impossible, of course, to find replacements for these legends but for a brief while, Pakistan seemed to have found a few reasonably worthy successors in Shaheen Afridi, Naseem Shah and Haris Rauf, among others. But for various reasons, no one has really taken things by the scruff of the neck and established themselves as a long-haul strike force. That, coupled with declining batting standards in all formats, have emphatically pegged Pakistan cricket back.

There is no quick fix or early solution in sight. For Pakistan to take even baby steps towards becoming a consistently competitive outfit, the first non-negotiable ingredients are faith and patience. Constant chopping and changing, of selection panels, of captains and players, and of the coaching staff, has been nothing if not counter-productive. While it will be impossible for them to replicate the Indian model, for obvious reasons, maybe they can have a look across the border to figure out what systems the Board of Control for Cricket in India has in place and how it has worked to the benefit of cricket in India. There needs to be a systemic revamp in Pakistan, at the foremost of which is a shift in thinking, in attitude and mindset. To continue to keep making the same mistakes and then hope for a different outcome is both naïve and foolhardy. The post-Lord's developments haven't done anyone any credit, and certainly not with the final act of the series due to play itself out in Birmingham from next Wednesday. Pakistan must realise that unless they set their house in order, the road to redemption will be strewn with thorns and boulders, prickly and unmovable.



THE GIST

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